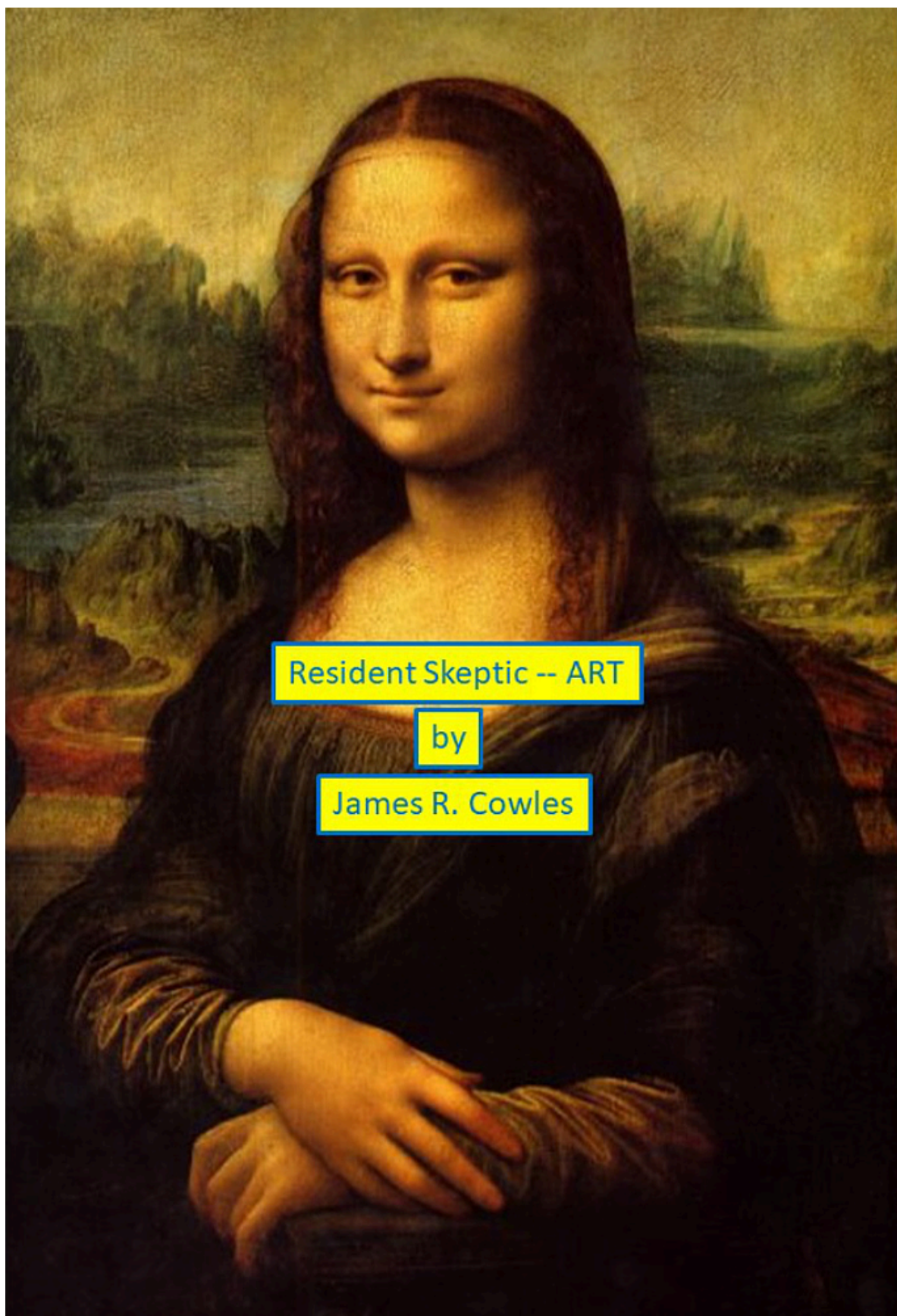




Resident Skeptic -- ART

by

James R. Cowles

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Art and Culture

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Chapter 1 – The Languages of Aging

The latest (3 January) issue of *Forbes* references a *Washington Post* op-ed by Prof. Laura L. Carstensen, professor of psychology and the Fairleigh S. Dickinson Jr. professor in public policy at Stanford University, on the semiotics of aging started me reflecting about what I want to be called, and what I do *not* want to be called, now that I am pushing 70. (I will be 69 in April of 2018.) Words matter. And – over time measured in multiple years – certain words / terms have become increasingly patronizing because I have, over that same interval of time, come to think of myself more and more, not as middle-aged, but simply as *old*. Prof. Carstensen is right: *By failing to identify with “old,” the story about old people remains a dreary one about loss and decline. Language matters: We need a term that aging people can embrace.* The following is how I learned how to identify with “old”, and also became sensitized to the clandestine insults, usually well-intended, that are couched in the language we use to talk about aging.

I did not begin to think of myself as old until the thrice-damned sciatica hit. That was during the first week of September, 2012. Prior to that time, I would regularly go walking 3 to 5 miles 3 to 5 days a week on the Soos Creek Trail a couple of miles from my house. Even if I occasionally walked 5 miles 5 days a week, even that level of activity felt merely pleasantly challenging, no more. But then in the first week of September, 2012, came the sciatica. (I will spare us both the back story.) In a couple of days, I went from being able to walk 5 miles a day, 5 days a week, to being barely able to walk across the room without weeping with pain. Through a veil of tears, I **forced** myself to exercise, first, by walking perhaps 1/8 of a mile a day 2 days a week, then finally, after a couple of years “gutting” my way up to 2 or 3 miles a day 2 or 3 days a week. Result: by age 63, I had learned how to walk like a true and hopeless invalid: stooped, taking baby steps (with subvocal whimpering if I were going uphill), and with frequent rests every several-dozen steps. I believed a wheelchair was in my future.

After roughly five years, what ultimately saved my cookies was the intervention of an excellent chiropractor, Dr. Steven Ryan, whose clinic is perhaps 2 miles from my front door. A life-long skeptic of chiropractic medicine, I only saw Dr. Ryan out of sheer desperation. I am a skeptic no longer. At the end of my first 20-minute session with “Dr. Steve” in early July of 2017, I walked away improved more than in the previous 5 years of physical therapy, acupuncture, and massage combined. So I began to see him 3 days a week in early July of 2017, and by the middle of September, 2017, I was essentially cured – *provided* I did my morning and evening stretching exercises with OCD-like regularity. I can no longer walk my customary 5 miles a day, 5 days a week, but I can do at least 3 miles a day at least 3 days a week. So there is a quasi-happy ending. And if I extrapolate my present “improvement curve” ... who knows?

As the pain gradually receded, what I was left with in its stead, like rich topsoil deposited by the flooding of the Nile, was an immeasurably greater ability to truly empathize with, e.g., Tolstoy’s Ivan Ilyich in “The Death of Ivan Ilyich”, who said that, yes, he knew all men are mortal, that Socrates is a man, and that therefore Socrates is mortal ... but nevertheless concludes “Socrates, yes – but not me, not little Vanya!” Unlike Ivan Ilyich, now I know “in the biblical sense” and on a gut level, as the aftermath of sciatica, that Tolstoy’s syllogism really does include “me, little Jimmy”. I am duly chastened: I now know, also on a gut level, that I am mortal. So I over-the-top agree with Prof. Carstensen: indeed, *Language matters ... [w]e need a term that aging people can embrace.*

I am not sure I know what words “aging people can embrace,” and I am even less sure that I know what words I, personally, can embrace. But I **damn** well *do* know of a couple that I reject out of hand, usually with extreme prejudice, and sometimes even with more than a little heat and sense of offense. So I approach this issue primarily from a negative standpoint: what *not* to do, what *not* to say. *Speaking only for myself*, I hereby admonish one and all to not ever, under any circumstances, refer to me as ...

o A “life-long learner” ... Are you familiar with the expression “Damn with faint praise”? (As in, e.g., “Prof. Stephen Hawking is a competent physicist” ... “Yitzhak Perlman plays a pretty good fiddle” ... I think you get the idea.) Well, there should also be a companion locution: “*Insult* with faint praise”. Think for a moment. If your experience is anything like mine, I would wager you have never heard the label “life-long learner” applied to, e.g., a student in her, say, early 20s, who has just finished her bachelor’s degree in some field, and has been accepted into a graduate school. Or a student who has finished a degree in some field, and is applying to colleges to be admitted to study a different field for a second baccalaureate degree. I have never heard anyone in either category called a “life-long learner”. Only old(er) people.

The implication clearly is that, when you walk off the stage with your diploma and when you are old enough that, because of limited time if for no other reason, your allegedly superannuated brain is allegedly past its “use-by” date so that its next subway stop is labeled “Dementia”, you should simply stop asking questions that begin with words like “Why?” and “How?”, especially “Why” and “How” questions whose answers, if and when you discover them, have no immediate utilitarian value.

In other words, old people cannot be philosophers or theoreticians.

But sometime in 2012, as a result of a back story too long to relate, I asked for and obtained permission from the University of Washington law school to audit classes in constitutional law and the First Amendment, purely on a non-credit, non-participatory basis. (The University of Washington has a wonderful program called ACCESS whereby anyone above age 60 can audit almost any class at UW for a mere token fee.) When people learned what I was doing, especially the young students in my con-law classes, they looked at me as if I had grown a second head. (The law school students were puzzled but never insulting, least of all condescending, toward me, despite my never having been even a law-school student, much less a practicing attorney. We had some excellent conversations before / after class and during the breaks. To some of the students, in fact, I became a kind of Yoda-figure: strange it was, ennobling I found it!) But everyone wondered: why was I paying money (the \$30 or so ACCESS audit fee)? undertaking a grueling round-trip commute from East Hill Kent to UW? voluntarily signing up for tons of reading in a \$200 casebook that itself weighed tons? spending hours at home immersing myself in case law, which raised even more questions that kicked off even more reading (some of which, especially on the “dormant” commerce clause, I did while kicked back on a beach in Hawaii and sipping a beer ... yes, I am serious)? They were even more astonished when they learned that *I was doing all this half-crippled with a severely compressed sciatic nerve* that made walking from the parking lot *uphill* to the law school at UW an exercise in pain-endurance worthy of *Game of Thrones*. (Remember: all this was before I discovered Dr. Ryan in 2017.) All to take a course that would not count toward a degree and in whose discussions, as an auditor, I was usually not allowed to participate. (For the record, I do support UW's auditor non-participation policy.) **Why?**

The implication clearly is that, as a matter of course and for lack of ability to do otherwise, old people will turn their brains off and renounce even the pretense of gratuitous and passionate curiosity ... at

least about anything more demanding than better ways to keep their breakfast oatmeal from dribbling from their toothless mouths and down their chins. So says the "elderly / senior" stereotype. **I vehemently disagree.** On the contrary, I think T. S. Eliot was right: "Old men ought to be explorers". (Women, too, but Eliot was no one's idea of a feminist!)

*Old men ought to be explorers
Here and there does not matter
We must be still and still moving
Into another intensity
For a further union, a deeper communion*

Alfred, Lord Tennyson's "Ulysses" was an old man when he began his second voyage, with his elderly crew, to explore parts of the world he missed during his first voyage. Would anyone be foolhardy enough to patronize or to condescend to Ulysses, the man who blinded Polyphemus, by calling Ulysses a "life-long learner"? As it turned out, my participation, even as an auditor, in the con-law classes and the classes on the First Amendment was an almost religious experience that renovated my knowledge of history and my political ideology from the bone marrow outward. **Bottom line: never shut down your brain.** You will seem odd only to people who have already shut down theirs.

o "Spiritual" ... I am also not terribly enthusiastic about being described as "spiritual", though in this case, my animus is almost purely idiosyncratic, rooted in my personal experience with matters theological and religious. Again, the term "spiritual" is nearly always applied to me with the intent of complimenting me. Problem is, given my history, this presumptive compliment often comes across as telling me I do a killer cosplay-impersonation of Adolf Hitler. Not all the time. My in-law family -- basically, my Tribe -- almost never uses the "s-word" to refer to me, and even when they do, it is never with that intent. But then, my in-law family is Buddhist, not Judaeo-Christian. (And yes, I do understand that the term "Judaeo-Christian" is itself highly problematical. But let's leave that rant for another time, shall we, because it is not relevant at the moment, anyway.) When Westerners tell me I am "spiritual," however, they tend to mean that I have an exceptional affinity with the monotheistic God of Judaeo-Christianity, of whom Prof. Richard Dawkins has aptly observed:

The God of the Old Testament is arguably the most unpleasant character in all fiction: jealous and proud of it; a petty, unjust, unforgiving control-freak; a vindictive, bloodthirsty ethnic cleanser; a misogynistic, homophobic, racist, infanticidal, genocidal, filicidal, pestilential, megalomaniacal, sadomasochistic, capriciously malevolent bully.

The only thing worse than being implicitly characterized as a "good Nazi" is being characterized as a "good *elderly* Nazi". Thanks but no thanks. *Again, I fully realize that is **not** the intent of the speaker, quite the contrary.* So I concentrate on the intent behind the words, and I am usually OK. But, intent aside, the words and their surface meaning serve to remind me that I spent roughly 55 years as a devotee of a religious faith that (a) I could never get the "hang-uv", and (b) that I probably would not have wanted to get the "hang-uv" if, during those 55 years, I had ever stopped to think deeply and with no cherry-picking about what I believed and what I was doing. Once I stopped cherry-picking, I realized that I had been trying to earn the validation of Prof. Dawkins' god, and that nothing could restore the years the locust had eaten, *contra* Joel 2:25. That is a deeply unsettling insight to accompany one into the latter part of life. So, regardless of intent, "spiritual" does more harm than good.

So what is the bottom line for me? Two words: *carpe diem* -- "Seize the day". Today. This day. This moment. Right now. Perhaps paradoxically, I do find compensatory wisdom, and a kind of austere comfort as I age, in a single biblical text: *[B]ehold, now is the accepted time; behold, now is the day of salvation.* (II Corinthians 6:2) Back in my fundamentalist evangelical days, I interpreted this text to mean that one had best walk forward during the revival meeting, shake the evangelist's hand, kneel, and ask God's forgiveness, lest one get smeared on the freeway driving home from church. Now I see it as expressing a deeper wisdom: **now**, **this** moment, is the only moment that is real, the only moment we have, the only moment we *can* have.

In that sense, and to that extent, age is irrelevant.

Chapter 2 – The Community of Readers

In *Shadowlands*, the movie about the courtship and marriage of C. S. Lewis and Joy Davidman Gresham, C. S. Lewis is quoted as saying “We read to know we are not alone”. I have found multitudes of citations where people quote Lewis as having said this in those very words, but have so far found no specific source, no book, no article, no lecture, for this remark. But even if Lewis did not say it, he *should* have. For in my own personal experience, there have been instances too abundant to count where this proved to be the case with uncanny timeliness. The following examples do not even scratch the surface. But in virtually all cases of where I have been reminded that I am not alone, this reminder also amounted to a revelation of *what I myself thought* even at times when I was not aware of it. Not only was I not aware that other people thought such things, I myself was unaware, at least on a conscious level, that I did so. The act of reading is revelatory, not only of the thoughts, beliefs, and conclusions of others, but reading also has a way of lifting into consciousness what I believe.

One of the most powerful examples of this revelation of self through the revelation of others, and probably the earliest such example, was the first time I read Alfred, Lord Tennyson’s great poem “Ulysses” as an exercise assigned to me and my fellow eighth-graders in Mr. Gordon Morse’s AP English class at Horace Mann Intermediate School, now Horace Mann Middle School, in Wichita, KS. I remember going home that night with my mimeographed copy of the poem tucked inside a filing folder in my briefcase – GAWD A’MIGHTY ... I was a nerd before the word was ever coined! – and taking the sheet out in my bedroom to read as I waited for dinner. (I always did my English reading and homework first, because it was my favorite class.) I was instantly mesmerized by Tennyson’s lines, lines I can recite *verbatim* from memory now, words that had been echoing back and forth in my mind since I read my first paragraph in the eighth grade:

*I am a part of all that I have met;
Yet all experience is an arch wherethro'
Gleams that untravell'd world whose margin fades
For ever and forever when I move. ...
[V]ile it were
For some three suns to store and hoard myself,
And this gray spirit yearning in desire
To follow knowledge like a sinking star,
Beyond the utmost bound of human thought.*

All this was written by an upper-class Englishman during Victoria's reign over 100 years before I was even born. Through his character of Ulysses, he spoke of that kind of restlessness I had known all my life, the kind of restlessness that made me the butt of all the jokes of the more athletically, and less academically, inclined boys (and their coaches!) in eighth-grade boys’ gym, the restlessness that drove me to pack my telescope when we visited relatives in the Arkansas wilderness so I could take advantage of the darkness (we still used kerosene lanterns then) to look at the moon, Saturn, Jupiter, the Pleiades, and, with my naked eye, the luminous smudge I later learned was the great Andromeda galaxy. Tennyson and his Ulysses knew that restlessness a century before I ever drew breath. I was not alone. As C. S. Lewis insightfully observed in his spiritual autobiography *Surprised by Joy, Nothing, I suspect, is more astonishing in any man's life than the discovery that there do exist people very, very like himself.*

And not just Tennyson. When I was about the same age, maybe even a little younger, I discovered Shakespeare. (I asked my mother then for a copy of Shakespeare's complete works for my birthday, which she gave me. I still have that book.) I was surprised to find a kindred spirit in Hamlet, whose existential brooding echoed my own:

To die, to sleep; To sleep: perchance to dream: ay, there's the rub; For in that sleep of death what dreams may come When we have shuffled off this mortal coil, must give us pause: there's the respect That makes calamity of so long life; ...who would fardels bear, To grunt and sweat under a weary life, but that the dread of something after death, the undiscover'd country from whose bourn no traveller returns, puzzles the will and makes us rather bear those ills we have than fly to others that we know not of? Thus conscience does make cowards of us all ...

As you can probably see, I was a rather morbidly introspective kid, all the more so because of my adolescent susceptibility to abysmally hopeless crushes on utterly unattainable girls and to the accompanying existential *angst* that afflicts the philosophically minded, especially at that age. Being smart ain't all it's cracked up to be, especially when your love of literature renders you empathetically vulnerable to the *angst* of **others**. But, again, as with Tennyson and his Ulysses, the compensatory benison is an awareness that, emotional rip-tides notwithstanding, at least I **knew** I was not alone.

Eventually, I did grow some protective scar tissue, in the form of a precocious skepticism and cynicism. One inexhaustible source for this astringently stinging balm of Gilead was Thomas Hardy, whose poem "Christmas 1924," reflecting on the horrors of chemical weapons in the First World War recently concluded, was like mercurochrome on a raw wound, but no less therapeutic for all that.

*'Peace upon earth!' was said. We sing it,
And pay a million priests to bring it.
After two thousand years of mass
We've got as far as poison-gas.*

The comfort of knowing you are not alone is not an unmixed blessing, however. For I also discovered Ezra Pound's rage against the profligate waste of war in his great anti-war -- and anti-usury -- poem as an indictment of Western civilization "Hugh Selwyn Mauberley":

... liars in public places.

*Daring as never before, wastage as never before.
Young blood and high blood,
Fair cheeks, and fine bodies;*

Fortitude as never before

*Frankness as never before,
disillusions as never told in the old days,
hysterias, trench confessions,
laughter out of dead bellies.*

*There died a myriad,
And of the best, among them,
For an old bitch gone in the teeth,
For a botched civilization,*

*Charm, smiling at the good mouth,
Quick eyes gone under earth's lid,*

*For two gross of broken statues,
For a few thousand battered books.*

Gradually, into my middle and late teens, I found myself almost being sucked past the event horizon of my adolescent cynicism and skepticism, and possibly toward the ultimate singularity of suicide, all because I could not find any source of hope or moderation or reason for optimism. The fact that I was not going there alone was scant comfort. But then I discovered two writers who remain critical to my equilibrium to this day: Albert Camus and T. S. Eliot, both of whom I discovered at roughly the same time as a freshman in college -- the former in my first philosophy course; the latter just through independent reading: I suffered greatly from an **in**ability to ignore texts merely because the course syllabus did not require them.

To this day, I can recite verbatim, in both French and English, the opening paragraph of Camus' *The Myth of Sisyphus*, from which I graduated to the writings of the Romanian philosopher E. M. Cioran (living in Paris and writing in French), though there is not enough space to even summarize the latter. The opening sentences of *Sisyphus* are (my translation from the French):

There is but one truly serious philosophical problem, and that is suicide. Judging whether life is or is not worth living amounts to answering the fundamental question of philosophy. All the rest ... are games; one must first answer this. And if it is true, as Nietzsche says, that a philosopher, to deserve our respect, must teach by example, you can appreciate the importance of this reply, for it will precede the definitive act. These are facts the heart can feel, but they call for careful analysis before they become clear to the intellect.

And later in *Sisyphus* I was haunted by (again, my translation):

It happens that the stage sets collapse. Rising, streetcar, four hours in the office or the factory, meal, streetcar, four hours of work, meal, sleep, and Monday Tuesday Wednesday Thursday Friday and Saturday according to the same rhythm-this path is easily followed most of the time. But one day the "why" arises and everything begins in that weariness tainted with amazement.

And all this time, I thought I was the only person on the planet to whom Camus' "Why" had ever occurred! I wish I could describe in words the liberation I experienced the first time I read these words. Somewhere out there, there really **are** other people – probably **most** other people, if we are to believe Camus – just like me. Not only was I not alone, if anything, *I was the rule, not the exception.*

But the problem remained: Camus' "Why". Monotheistic religion in general, and Christianity in particular, had long since failed me. I continued going to church during this time just to please my parents – who were, after all, paying the bills for my education – and also, frankly, out of sheer habit.

But for a long time, Christianity had felt like an exercise in Dietrich Bonhoeffer's "cheap grace" or maybe life in some kind of surveillance state like North Korea, where one is being perpetually *evaluated* – another "it's not just me" experience I skate over for lack of space – and it continued to feel that way until I discovered both the biography and writings of the man I still consider the greatest religious poet in the English language: Thomas Stearns Eliot.

Suffice to say that what I found in Eliot was a kindred spirit who also saw Christianity as fatally devoid of one of the defining parameters of human – not just Western or Christian – spirituality: **tragedy**. The all-consuming glory of Christ's Resurrection simply, as we would say today, "sucks all the air out of the room," and thus annihilates all the categories of Tragedy. Christians are fond of saying Christ's victory is complete. They are right. That's just the problem: it is **too** complete, too complete to leave any room for, e.g., Dostoyevsky, for Unamuno's "tragic sense of life". (So it should not require a precocious imagination to understand why for a time I buried myself in the writings of Miguel de Unamuno of the University of Salamanca. But again, there is no time ...) After 50 years of, not merely reading, but living inside of, Eliot's poetry, from *The Wasteland* to "Ash Wednesday" to *Four Quartets*, I have come to believe that Eliot's singular achievement is to reconcile the Christian myth with tragedy, in fact, to show that the former is incomplete and impoverished without the latter. I have spent most of my life "decoding" Eliot's meaning, especially of the *Quartets*, with the serendipitous help of an experience I had at St. Nicholas Church in Galway, Ireland, and within the *Quartets* especially of "Little Gidding". This is obviously too long a story to even synopsise here. I would only invite you to embark on the same quest by reflecting on the concluding lines:

*A condition of complete simplicity
(Costing not less than everything)
And all shall be well and
All manner of thing shall be well
When the tongues of flames are in-folded
Into the crowned knot of fire
And the fire and the rose are one.*

And if you do undertake this journey, I can, from personal experience, promise you: you will not be alone. In fact, you will be accompanied by illustrious companions as a "cloud of witnesses".

Chapter 3 – Courage Has a Face

AMSTERDAM – It is impossible to spend any significant time at all in this city, i.e., more than one day, and not be conscious of the influence and the sheer perennial presence of two of the greatest spirits who haunt it most persistently: Rembrandt van Rijn and Vincent Van Gogh. I spent a lot of time here in the middle 2000s on business for Boeing's commercial airplane division, working out of the inventory-planning offices, at Schiphol Airport, of KLM-Royal Dutch Airlines. In the process, I had ample time to visit all the great art museums in the city – the Rijksmuseum, the Van Gogh Museum, and the Stedelijk museum of modern / contemporary art. My wife and I also spent a lot of time here, partly on business when Diane occasionally accompanied me on my business trips and partly for pleasure. It remains our most frequented city in Europe.

This last trip during the first half of October was no exception. What I took away from this latest visit to Amsterdam was a persistent sense of moral insight regarding, not only the art of Rembrandt and Van Gogh, but also, and in a sense perhaps more importantly, of the way aficionados of those two great artists, no doubt inadvertently and unconsciously, often tend to patronize them when the people who appreciate their art sometimes merge their art with their biographies in a way that diminishes the stature of the latter. As I wandered around with Diane among the paintings of Rembrandt at the Rijksmuseum and of Van Gogh at the Van Gogh Museum, it dawned on me that, like many lovers of their art, I, too, had allowed the art to paradoxically diminish the stature of the men who created it.

To an extent arguably greater than with any other great artists, people who think, teach, and talk about the art of Rembrandt and Van Gogh almost always *segue* seamlessly into biography. Of course, this is true of any great painter or writer or composer. People who love and study the music of Beethoven cannot help but reflect on Beethoven's progressively more severe deafness, a deafness that eventually drove him to cut the legs off his piano so the piano could lie flat on the floor and Beethoven could lie beside it, ear pressed to floor, and listen to his music via bone conduction as he composed. But it seems to me that the art of Rembrandt and Van Gogh is intertwined with their respective biographies to an extent unequalled with the works of other artists. Alberto Giacometti was a great sculptor, but I know of no art critics who merge Giacometti's works with his life to any degree remotely approximating the same seamlessness I encounter with Rembrandt and Van Gogh. Ditto Alexander Calder and his mobiles or Matisse and his cut-outs. We also similarly tend to keep Shakespeare separate from his plays. But it is much different with Rembrandt and Van Gogh, whose paintings are – to borrow a term coined by a late professor of mine at Tufts – “intrinsicated” with their biographies.

A mere stroll through Rembrandt's paintings in the Rijksmuseum or through those of Van Gogh in the Van Gogh Museum makes obvious the reasons for this symbiosis of art and artist: both Rembrandt and Van Gogh bequeathed to us an inheritance of self-portraits unexcelled, probably unequalled, by any other painter. For example, you will search in vain for any self-portrait by Vermeer among the bare few-dozen surviving works of his that survive. (The one Vermeer that might, perhaps, be a self-portrait is a painting of an artist -- perhaps Vermeer, perhaps not -- **seen from behind** as the artist is painting a portrait of a subject.) By contrast, Rembrandt and Van Gogh used their faces as a means of reflecting on life, on the random effects of chance and circumstance, and of the effects of both on the artist -- not, it should be noted, in any narcissistic sense, but rather because they both seemed to consider themselves typical of the Universal Man. (Compare any of Rembrandt's or Van Gogh's self-portraits with the exercise in self-regard that just is the self-portrait commissioned by Donald Trump, and the difference will be slap-upside-the-head obvious.) This Universal-Man motif of their works

positively invites biography. In fact, it would probably be possible to take all their self-portraits, arrange them chronologically, and, in the end, have a biography of both artists executed in the medium of pigment instead of print.

The question then becomes of how we react to both the artists and the art in light of that spectrum of their respective experiences. To address this question, we have to consider historical issues that lie outside the purview of the self-portraits. For example, it is important to remember that Rembrandt lived through the horrors of the Thirty Years War. Rembrandt was born in 1606 and died in 1669. The Thirty Years War began in 1618 and ended with the Treat of Westphalia in 1648. So Rembrandt's lifetime contained the entirety of this violent period when most of central Europe was consumed by the violence of unbridled religious passion. Entire cities and towns were devastated, many over and over again, by religious conflict. The Netherlands in general, and Amsterdam in particular, were largely untouched physically, but Rembrandt did live during the time of Holland's war of independence from Spain. He also lived during a time of the efflorescence of Dutch culture and economic prosperity. The first line of Dickens' *A Tale of Two Cities* could be applied to Holland during this time: "It was the best of times, it was the worst of times". Both halves of this statement -- violence and peace, prosperity and poverty -- left their respective stamps on Rembrandt himself and on his work. Both are reflected in his self-portraits.

Analogous remarks apply to Van Gogh, who lived during a similar time of political and cultural flux. Van Gogh was born in 1853, immediately following the great political upheavals that shook Europe during the revolutions of 1848. He began to flourish as an artist during the time of the great aesthetic transformations occasioned by the impressionist movement. But this aesthetic revolution was not only, or even primarily, a greater freedom of line and color, but also, perhaps especially, of subject matter.

Like his impressionist cousins, Van Gogh began to paint subjects hitherto considered inappropriate for "serious" art: Belgian coal-miners in the Borinage region of southern Belgium, still lifes of well-worn wooden shoes commonly worn by Belgian and Dutch peasants, etc. He also began to paint outside: his studio was Nature itself, not Nature-inside-the-*atelier*. Both the subject matter and his free brushwork and use of impasto made his paintings enigmatic at best, ugly at worst, to the upper-class art collectors of Paris and Brussels. (As far as I have been able to determine, he sold -- perhaps -- only one of his paintings to a wealthy collector in Paris: his *Red Vines* depicting grape vines in a vineyard. And I am by no means certain of even that.) Also, like many of his impressionist cousins, his life was not the life of polite society that was expected by many upper-class artists. (Even before he became an artist full-time, he was summarily fired from his first job as a chaplain to the coal miners of the Borinage for not dressing the part of a representative of the Dutch Reformed Church: starched collar, cravat, waistcoat, and good shoes. Vincent had the scandalous idea that he should "incarnate" himself in the lives of the miners to whom he ministered by dressing, eating, and living as they did. His choice of an artist's life forever alienated him from his father, a rift that never healed.) Toulouse-Lautrec painted the bistro life of Paris, including advertisements for fashionable singers and impresarios. Van Gogh lived off the generosity of his brother Theo and Theo's wife Johanna. (We owe a [debt](#) of gratitude to the latter for the preservation of most of Van Gogh's work, and those works comprise the core of the Van Gogh Museum's collection. And if you have never seen the late Leonard Nimoy's one-man depiction of Theo and his response to his brother, by all means, run-don't-walk, locate it, and watch it.) Desperate for love and companionship, Vincent lived with a prostitute and her child for a time. His letters to Theo are often heart-wrenching in their desperation for a companion, a lover, or just a friend. (He famously held his bare hand over a candle flame while he addressed proposal of marriage to a

distant cousin, Kee Vos, who rejected him.) But what strikes me again and again, as I wander through the self-portraits of both men, is that, in spite of poverty, in spite of rejection, in spite of social isolation -- **they painted what they wanted to paint**, not necessarily what others, potential clients / customers, *wanted* to see or what those clients / customers considered "suitable" or "appropriate". That was true of Rembrandt even during times of prosperity -- Rembrandt was forced to declare bankruptcy at least twice, perhaps three times -- and it was true of Van Gogh all his life, up until the fatal suicide gun-shot that ended his life and that culminated with his burial beside his beloved brother Theo. With both Rembrandt and Van Gogh, we see lives of uncompromised and uncompromising professional and aesthetic courage. **Their self-portraits conclusively prove that *courage has a face*.**

As should be obvious by now, I admire them both unreservedly and without qualification. The problem I am left with, however, is the reaction of art lovers -- myself included -- who, altogether understandably, empathize with both artists, but who allow this empathy to degenerate into something much less charitable, something that diminishes the stature of both men. I think Don McLean's song "Starry, Starry Night" captures just the right blend of empathy and pathos without, for all that, degenerating into pity. There is a fine line between empathy and pity, and I fear that, sometimes, we cross that line. Empathy is good. *But pity belittles, infantilizes, and ultimately emasculates those against whom it is, often with the best of intentions, directed.* What we admirers of Rembrandt and Van Gogh often do not understand -- and what we need to understand, perhaps more than anything else -- is that **both Rembrandt and Van Gogh were men of towering strength** who were determined to pursue their art at all cost. And who did so. Even with their talents and their gifts, I could never do what they did. They deserve admiration. They deserve respect. They deserve empathy. They do not deserve pity. They are far, far better than that.

They deserve better of us, their admirers.

Chapter 4 – Beyond the Bounds of Realism with *Hyper-Realism*

One of the customary criticisms of what we may generically call “modern” art is that the bizarre distortions of the figures in the works – even music, e.g., the works of John Cage – render the art inaccessible to any but the most sophisticated tastes and temperaments. Such critics point to, e.g., Picasso’s “Les Demoiselles d’Avignon” and Duchamp’s “Nude Descending a Staircase” as examples of modern art’s alienation from the public. (The late evangelical Christian writer Francis Schaeffer even went so far as to argue that “Nude” was actually *evil and sinful*, because it was a form of pornography in that it encouraged the viewer to search the image for a picture of a naked woman!) Compare Picasso and Duchamp, et al., with, e.g., the great landscape artists of the Hudson River School and artists of the American landscape like Albert Bierstadt.

The latter we usually call “realists”. But an interesting phenomenon seems to have been developing since the 70s in that some artists – I will concentrate on Duane Hansen, though there are many others – who pushed the aesthetic canons of realistic, representational art to the point that their realism is *so real as to actually blur the distinction between realism and non-realism* ... even perhaps even something approaching **surrealism**. The former, when pushed to the ragged edge of its limits as an artistic idiom, transitions into something like the latter. At that point, realism becomes, in a sense, more real than the real subject of the painting and becomes **hyperrealism**.

Beginning in the 1970s, *hyperrealism* grew out of the previous movement of *photorealism*, but with some important differences. Perhaps the most salient difference between photorealism and hyperrealism is that photorealistic artists like John Baeder, Ralph Goings, and Chuck Close attempted to capture and reproduce photographs with great verisimilitude, with no attempt at embellishment or alteration. What *photorealist* artists like Baeder, Goings, and Close were concerned to do in two dimensions, Duane Hansen attempts in three with his *hyperrealistic* sculptures. However, this is not the only, or even the most important, difference.

Whereas photorealists were usually concerned to depict their subjects in near-photographic detail with no attempt at commentary, least of all political or social critique, hyperrealists like Hansen are quite unabashed at incorporating into their figures an element of social critique and commentary, often even at the expense of representational accuracy. Sometimes, in fact, Hansen’s figures perceptibly shade over into stereotype and even, arguably, sexism. Furthermore, it is by no means altogether clear whether Hansen’s intent in these depictions is parody, satire, or even elitist arrogance. That intent is entirely up to the viewer. Consider, for example, two of Hansen’s better-known works: “Tourists” and “Housewife”.

Seriously, has anyone, anywhere ever actually seen tourists dressed as the two figures, presumably husband and wife, are dressed? I have not. Aloha shirts, yes. Sandals, yes. Cameras, yes. But multiple cameras? No. (I do not know, but I strongly suspect that “Tourists” was created before high-end cellphones with professional-quality photographic systems were available.) I have even heard tourists ask dumb questions. E.g., on my first visit to Washington, DC, I was exiting the Capitol after the usual tour, walking behind two fellow tourists, and heard the wife ask the husband “OK ... we’ve seen the Senate and we’ve seen the House of Representatives ... so when are we going to see the *Congress*?” Only the desire to avoid making a scene enabled me to refrain from banging my head against the wall, and thereby attracting the attention of a Capitol guard, as I walked out the East Front. But as to

appearance, *my two politically challenged fellow tourists looked pretty much as I did* in jeans, sneakers, t-shirt, and carrying a little Instamatic camera.

I do not believe that Hansen, in “Tourists,” is guilty of classism – in this case, looking down his nose at actual tourists, but rather satirizing stereotypical tourists in his parody of typical Washington, DC – or anywhere else – sightseers. “Tourists” is vulnerable to this criticism only in an environment which is dominated by a sensibility already “pre-engineered” to take offense, and that is consequently unable to laugh at itself. “Tourists” is hyper-realism in the sense that *Mad* magazine, in its satirical treatment of popular culture, was likewise, in the 60s and 70s, was also hyper-realistic in its depiction of, e.g., advertising executives, popular culture (e.g., The Lone Ranger, Star Trek, and the X-Files), and with a similar intent to evoke laughter – in this case, laughter at ourselves – rather than rage. Unfortunately, *hyper-realism*, when employed satirically / parodically, can irritate our *hyper-sensitive* offense-prone culture.

Similar remarks apply to Hansen’s “Housewife,” if anything, even more pertinently. How are we to interpret his depiction of a slovenly housewife relaxing under a hair dryer with her feet resting on an ottoman and reading a magazine? Is this an instance of blatant sexism? I seriously doubt it. I believe the object of the parody is *not housewifery, but, in some parts of the country, a certain outdated and obsolete, but conception of housewifery*. As with “Tourists,” Hansen is satirizing / parodying us. His work asks us “Is this seriously, really what we believe housewives do all day?”: dry their hair, read cheap magazines, and smoke cigarettes? In particular, Hansen’s “Housewife” is an implicit but astringent critique of certain parts of feminism that see being “only” a housewife as unmitigated drudgery, a failure to pursue the vision of “having it all”. Again, and as with “Tourists,” the object of the satire is not the people / person being satirized, but the attitudes we bring to seeing them.

A much gentler motif of Hansen’s work may be observed in works like “Woman Eating,” “Janitor,” and “Museum Guard”. These works evince a kind of quiet dignity and their uncanny realism invites us to look – to look at people eating, to look at janitors, to look at museum guards, all of whom are most often almost invisible to us. Furthermore, the “hyper” in hyper-realism impels us to look closely and in detail. I am always fascinated when I encounter a work by Hansen, fascinated both by my own reaction and by the reactions of other museum-goers who encounter those works, it may be for the first time.

Invariably, we walk up to the figure – as closely as we can without setting off alarms – and examine the work as minutely as we can. One of the uncanny characteristics of Hansen’s work is what I will call *scale invariance*, i.e., no matter how closely you examine it, **the work always looks as realistic at small distances as it does from a distance**. I had an arresting experience of scale invariance once at the Museum of Contemporary Art in Chicago, where, for the first time, I encountered Hansen’s “Charity Worker”: a statue of a woman sitting at a table, reading (I think it was) a copy of *Reader’s Digest*, and waiting for people to drop coins in her collection can for – as I recall – the March of Dimes.

So I reached into my pocket, pulled out some loose change, and dropped it in the can. Only later, after examining other works in the same gallery, did I notice that *the woman had never moved*. After 15 minutes or so, I became concerned: maybe she had died on the job. So I went back to “Charity Worker” – and only then did I notice the placard on the wall that said “Charity Worker by Duane Hansen”. Scale invariance *a la* Duane Hansen deceives into noticing the previously un-notice-able, that which we previously considered – it may be literally – beneath notice. It shocks into paying attention.

Chapter 5 – Shhh! Don't Tell Anybody, but Art Can Be Fun!

Would someone please answer the following question for me: *Why do Americans – actually, I think Westerners generally, but I will stick with Americans – believe art is something that must be approached so ... well ... seriously?* With most art, most Americans seem to believe that, when looking at a painting or a piece of sculpture or seeing a play or listening to a piece of music, they are obligated, on pain of being branded as culture-phobic philistines, to wear a facial expression that tells the world **Pity me! I am dying of terminal hemorrhoids!**

Well, before anyone makes any cracks about that remark, I will back up a step or two and say that, yes, to be sure, some works of art are explicitly intended to evoke play, laughter, and light-hearted dalliance. A good example is Carlo Goldoni's rollicking *A Servant of Two Masters*, which I saw performed a few years ago at the Oregon Shakespeare Festival and laughed until I almost had a laundry problem.

Ditto movies like *Singin' in the Rain* and *Oklahoma!* and plays like Noel Coward's great *The Importance of Being Earnest*. Those works' very titles pretty much give their audiences permission to just kick back and have fun. Rather, I mean other works by quote-serious-unquote artists like Shakespeare. Ditto Bach. Ditto Mozart. Ditto Haydn. (Wagner? Well ... probably not, unless one is enamored of heavy-handed, unrelieved Teutonic seriousness. Hence Oscar Wilde's assertion, also attributed to Rossini, that Wagner's music "has some wonderful moments but some terrible half-hours".) It might be healthy to look at some great art that that *can* be exuberant fun, but that often evokes reactions of pathological seriousness, and so too often is greeted with about as much joy as ham sandwiches at a Jewish funeral reception.

Take, for example, the following musical compositions, which positively *call* for dance, concert-hall etiquette be damned.

o Mozart's "Violin Concerto No. 3 in G"

If you can listen to the gracefully galloping first movement of the "G Concerto" and not at least tap your toes, someone should hold a mirror under your nose because you may very well be dead. (Skip the damned ad as soon as you can and go directly to the piece.) In an inadvertent way, this YouTube clip was uproariously hilarious: the Pope and members of the most senior episcopal leadership of the Catholic Church sitting stock-still like Michelangelo statues or Egyptian bas reliefs while the music that was playing in front of them positively **demanded**, imperiously **commanded** to be danced to ... *anything except sitting the hell down!* The technical term for the emotion evoked by the first movement of Mozart's "G Concerto," Your Holiness, is **JOY**. Great roaring **Joy**. You may have heard of it, and, no, it is most decidedly not a rumor! And insofar as the experience of Joy can be instantiated in sound, Mozart did it. So stamp your feet. Clap. Sway back and forth in time to the music. Stand up, link arms, and do synchronized dance to the music like the women at the old Radio City Music Hall. Mozart was a genius. *But he was a genius at being a child*. Get down on the floor, bathe in his music, wallow in it shamelessly, and *be a child with him*. In other words ... Mozart's "G Concerto" invites us to be ... born again! Lessee ... where have you guys heard *that* before?

o Bach's "Brandenburg Concerto #3"

Some advice to morticians ... if you want to make sure your client really is dead before you embalm her or him, play the “Third Brandenburg” over a good stereo system in the embalming room. (Again, skip the thrice-damned ads as soon as you can!) If your client starts to twitch rhythmically, especially in the feet and legs, and maybe wave her arms to the same rhythm, put the embalming fluid back on the shelf and call the paramedics. You just lost a client. I mean, who “cadaver” think of such a grave undertaking? I believe it is historically true that the Margrave Christian Ludwig of Brandenburg, for whom Bach wrote this example of thrice-distilled joy, accepted the sheet music for all the “Brandenburgs” – then put the manuscript on a shelf to gather dust for God-only-knows how long. I do not know if he ever heard it performed. If not, his loss. Our gain.

o Bach’s “Brandenburg Concerto #4

My first exposure to Bach’s “4th Brandenburg” was in the music section on the mezzanine of the Wichita Public Library (WPL). I did not have a stereo, not even a Walkman -- remember those? -- so I would go to the WPL, find a vinyl record of the “Brandenburgs” and play it and play it and play it and play it. I do not know, but I may very well have worn out at least the grooves marking the first movement of the “Fourth”. I imagined myself wandering through a virgin landscape of unspoiled wilderness, accompanied by the songs of birds, rendered in the lilting rhythms of Bach’s incomparable composition. This is another case in point of knowing whether or not you are alive or dead, depending, respectively, on whether you can resist swaying in time to the movement of the music. If you can resist, and choose instead to observe the niceties of white-collar, Sphinx-like, formal immobility, then I feel very sorry for you. Also, again, this is music intended to induce radiant, irrepressible joy. There is no virtue in being able to resist. Unfortunately, all too many concert-goers can do just that.

o Franz Josef Haydn’s “String Quartet No. 4 in F-maj”

I have often thought that, if the European Enlightenment of the 18th century were to have theme music, much like an American sitcom or drama, one could do no better than to select Haydn’s “F-maj String Quartet No.4” for that purpose. It is graceful and lilting – but, for that reason, also just sheer fun – to a degree that simply beggars description. Westerners, especially Americans, usually stereotype the Enlightenment of the 18th century – the culture that gave us liberal, latitudinarian, constitutional democracy, free speech, free thought, reflexive suspicion of authoritarianism, equal rights for all, etc., etc. – in other words, all the values, principles, and priorities presently under siege by the likes of Donald Trump, Victor Orban, Marine LePen, Alternative for Germany, and the leave-EU movement that is so nostalgic for a Europe of hard borders and separate currencies like the 1940s – such people stereotype the Enlightenment as **too** free, **too** cosmopolitan, **too** rational, **too** far removed from the *Blut und Boden* (“Blood and Soil”) derangement that gave us two World Wars. Haydn’s number-4 string quartet in F-major is a refutation of that slobbering crudity in the form of music that is no less liltingly graceful for being compelling. It is sheer fun and dance in the service of civilization, something the Orbans and Trumps will never understand.

But it is not only in musical art that fun may be discovered. There is also sculpture. One of the best examples of sculpture-as-fun is a piece I once encountered on a street in downtown Leipzig, Germany. If you can look at this piece and not laugh, then you really should have your eyeglasses prescription revised. The figure in the sculpture is evidently marching along the sidewalk in giant goose-steps while stiff-arm saluting -- but with his -- at least, I am pretty sure it is a man -- head discreetly retracted down between his shoulders. Words fail me. Take a look at the images and see for yourself.

In fact, this piece illustrates a weapon whose effect on authoritarian people, ideologies, and governments is nothing short of subversive: humor. It is the sculptural equivalent of Alec Baldwin's impersonation of Trump on *Saturday Night Live*. It is also a 21st-century parody in the tradition of *Right In the Fuehrer's Face* from World War II. Make sure the sound is turned on in *both* your computer *and* on the YouTube clip itself.) Furthermore, remember that I encountered this sculpture on a sidewalk in Leipzig, Germany -- which was once a part of the dreary, gray, dystopian **un**-Paradise of East Germany until the Wall fell, and the Germanys united, to be followed by an efflorescence of art, especially music, sculpture, and architecture, the likes of which have not been seen since the Weimar Republic between the two World Wars. Leipzig was reborn. I know the old Leipzig only by reputation: I was forbidden to travel there or any Communist country on pain of having my security clearances lifted, but I have read a lot about the rebirth of that wonderful city of Bach, Wagner, Mendelssohn, *et al.*, where even the street violinists are world-class musicians. Part of the art that blossomed in Leipzig would have been sternly forbidden by its former communist taskmasters, who have, if anything, an even more sclerotic aesthetic sense than American museum- and concert-goers. Communists were about equally inept at having fun, like other authoritarians -- Trump, Orban, et al. The political culture that built the *Rundecke* -- "Round Corners" -- the headquarters of the East German *Stasi* in Leipzig, would never have permitted the display of this sculpture in Leipzig. They would have had as little use for that sculpture as Trump has for Alec Baldwin and *Saturday Night Live* -- and for essentially the same reasons.

The moral of my story? Only this: yes some art is serious, some art is intended to evoke a sense of sadness and tragedy ... of course ... e.g., *A Long Day's Journey Into Night* ... but when any work of art evinces or evokes or provokes humor, playfulness, dalliance, and whimsy -- **do not resist it**. You will only be that much poorer if you do. *Sophistication and taste do not equate to frowning, head-bowing, and chin-stroking*. One's aesthetic sensibilities should make room for a good, tear-inducing belly laugh -- Marx Brothers' *Horse Feathers* as high art. *Saturday Night Live* and *A Midsummer Night's Dream* can -- and do -- meet and embrace.

Chapter 6 – The This-Worldly Iconography of Pierre Auguste Renoir

Ever since my first exposure to it in a Smithsonian Institution art-history seminar in 1979, one of my favorite art venues in Washington, DC, has been the venerable Phillips Collection, a few blocks east and perhaps a block south of the DuPont Circle DC Metro stop.

There are many reasons for my respect and enthusiasm for “the Phillips,” but certainly one of the most salient reasons for my “evangelical” work on behalf of the Collection is that the Phillips houses Pierre Auguste Renoir’s great *Luncheon of the Boating Party* (hereafter *Luncheon*). (I refuse to call it, as some critics do, *Boatman’s Lunch*. Computers are expensive and I would rather not throw up on mine.) Aside from the sheer beauty of the painting itself, I enjoy watching others’ reaction as they, no doubt in many cases for the first time, walk into the gallery that displays it, all to itself on one wall. Almost invariably – and I’m tempted to remove the “Almost” qualifier, since I can recall no exceptions – the patron, often not realizing that *Luncheon* hangs there, walks into the gallery, turns, and, often with hand to mouth, softly gasps “Aahhh!” I was no exception: the first time I saw Renoir’s great work, I gasped, too. Over the years, in looking again and again and again and again at *Luncheon*, and reflecting on my and others’ tendency to stare wide-eyed and gasping, I have come to some conclusions about why *Luncheon* elicits such uniform awe, and what those reasons tell us about the genius of Renoir and about our sensibilities as art enthusiasts.

For the sake of brevity – for similar examples could be adduced over and over from looking at the painting – I will restrict myself to a single minute examination of Renoir’s work. Take a moment and look at one small segment of the painting. (You may have to copy one of the images of *Luncheon* in this “Skeptic’s” column to your hard drive and stretch the image until the relevant corner of the painting is large enough to follow what ensues.) Look carefully in the “southwestern” corner of *Luncheon* and observe the young woman with the red-flowered hat playing with the little black dog. Look more closely. In particular, look at the eye of the little black dog. Closer still: observe that the eye of the little black dog is highlighted with *a single speck of white*. After years of visiting the Phillips, viewing the painting, and viewing others’ reactions thereto, I have concluded that, while there are many keys to the spell *Luncheon* casts over us, **one of the most salient keys is that single speck of white** in the little dog’s eye. (Remember, now, I am *concentrating*, *not generalizing*. To repeat: there are other keys to *Luncheon* and the reason for its effect on us, of which **that single speck of white** is only one, though I would argue one of the most important.) Anyway, consider the following counterfactual / hypothetical.

Just for the helluvit, try to reimagine *Luncheon* precisely as it is – *but with that single speck of white gone*. What would the effect be? Without that single, minute speck of white, the little dog’s eye loses its three-dimension-ality. The dog’s eye becomes just a flat, two-dimensional circle. But *with* that speck of white, the dog’s eye becomes three-dimensional, at least in the viewer’s iconic imagination, i.e., the dog’s eye becomes a *sphere*. In fact, with that speck of white, the little dog’s eye becomes ... well ... **the little dog’s eye becomes an eye**. A living eye. Without that speck of white, the young woman is basically playing with a stuffed animal, like a very young child. But with that speck of white, she becomes a young woman playing with a living creature. One step farther: I would argue that, without that speck of white, the young woman and her dog could, for all we viewers know, be a department-store mannequin posed to look like a young woman playing with her little dog. But with that minute speck of white – so exquisitely subtle, so eminently over-look-able! – girl-and-dog become

two living creatures involved in an intimate transaction of mutual love. *That “southwest” corner of Luncheon comes alive.*

But the effect is not restricted to that corner of the painting. For reasons of proximity of the figures to one another in the painting if nothing else, *that vibrant sense of alive-ness radiates outward* to the rest of *Luncheon*. The whole painting comes alive. I suppose that, in the strictest sense, I lied just now when I said that I would restrict my attention to the speck of white in the eye of the young woman’s dog. But it was a white lie. The reason the life of dog-and-girl radiates outward and breathes life to the rest of *Luncheon* is because, paradoxical as it may sound in an age that valorizes egocentricity, **the other figures in the painting all, without exception, ignore us.** There is no suggestion of animosity, not the slightest hint of alienation. We are welcome to observe. But *only* to observe. *Because the other figures in the painting ignore us, they are free to be themselves*, to interact as they will. Neither the viewer nor the painting is bound to the other. Neither painting nor patron is beholden to the other. That is why the *Luncheon* lives. In fact, in a not-altogether-metaphorical sense, *Luncheon* becomes more than a two-dimensional image. *Luncheon of the Boating Party* becomes a **window**, a window onto and into the lives of others – which it could not hope to be, were it bound to us with aesthetic chains. *Luncheon of the Boating Party lives.*

Which brings up a point on which the work of Renoir, in fact, many Impressionists, has been critiqued: its depiction of an idealized world devoid of tragedy. Has any party of friends having lunch together on a boat **ever** been as uniformly happy as the group of celebrants in *Luncheon*? Has any little girl with a watering can **ever** really been as innocent as the little girl with the watering can in Renoir’s renowned image? As innocent and guileless as the young ballet dancer in *Danseuse*? I suppose that depends on one’s experience with boating parties and with little girls with watering cans. (For the record: I have personally known a young ballet dancer who, at age 10 or 11, would bid fair to confirm Renoir’s image in all its purity. But that is neither here nor there.) In any case, such critiques presuppose the unqualified value of realism. Leveling such criticisms at Renoir is, I think, in many ways the product of an age and of a civilization, still recovering from two world wars and still subject to nuclear and environmental catastrophe, that is no longer capable of valuing innocence and purity. Renoir had a tragic life. For one thing, severe arthritis crippled his hands when he had years of productive life remaining for his art. The point? Only that to infer from *Luncheon* and *Little Girl with a Watering Can* that Renoir was unacquainted with grief and pain is a kind of reverse snobbery that is really unworthy of serious consideration.

Renoir’s purpose, I think, and his achievement, and the reason people still flock to the National Gallery of Art and the Phillips Collection, is, not to display the world as it is, as certainly he himself knew it was not, but rather to image forth a vision of something purer, or something better – which we so often, in what I can only call our “naïve cynicism” -- criticize as “unrealistic”. Another way to think of it: Renoir’s purpose is a kind of iconography, very much in the tradition of the religious iconography of Byzantine Christianity, which depicted a no-less-idealized world, but with a view to calling the worshipper to something more, something better. Renoir is a 20th-century, secular iconographer of a better reality. For Renoir exemplifies the late Robert F. Kennedy’s paraphrase of George Bernard Shaw: “Some men see things as they are and ask why, I dream things that never were and ask ‘Why not?’” *Luncheon of the Boating Party*, *Little Girl with a Watering Can*, *Danseuse*, et al., are all of the latter tradition.

They ask “Why not?”

Chapter 7 – Mourning Mad

Mad Magazine is no more ... a moment of silence, please ...

I grew up with *Mad* during the days immediately preceding puberty and into early puberty. The magazine was wonderfully iconoclastic for a kid who was confined by the suffocating strictures of hyper-fundamentalist Christianity – the church I grew up in thought Billy Graham was a dangerous liberal because he talked with the Pope occasionally ... seriously! – and parents with a grossly over-developed respect for sheer authority, especially church authority. Basically, my adolescence was eerily similar to what I imagine people go through who live in North Korea – constantly under surveillance, allowed almost no individual freedom, perpetually *evaluated* by the fundamentalist God (the Celestial Kim Jong Whoever *du jour*), etc., etc. But unlike North Koreans, I had a safety valve, an outlet for my frustration: humor in the form of *Mad Magazine* satires. Every month, I would scan the supermarket magazine shelves for the latest issue of *Mad* and would seize the latest copy.

My parents never objected to buying it for me, because most of the humor went over their heads, anyway. (Fundamentalists of the early 60s are like all fundamentalists of all periods: singularly ill-informed, undereducated, and therefore devoid of a sense of humor or irony.) They almost never read it, and almost never understood it on the rare occasions when they did. So I would take the latest issue home, go to my room, and mystify my parents with the howls of laundry-problem-inducing laughter they heard from behind the door. I even bought the paperback books – *The Mad Reader*, *Son of Mad*, *The Brothers Mad*, etc., etc. – that were often just reprints from the precursor to *Mad*: *EC Comics* that were published before my day. I also waited with bated breath for the yearly publication of the *Mad Annual* that reprised many of the articles from previous issues of the magazine, but that I had not read because I did, on occasion, miss a monthly issue. I also remember that, in the presidential election of 1960, Alfred E. Neuman ran for President under the slogan "Prosperity with Alfred E.!", thereby anticipating by 8 years the candidacy of Pat Paulsen.

The satire was priceless. Herewith URLs that link to excerpts. I refrain from publishing the actual images because there are so many, and because I do not have the time to look up the copyright protections. So if you want to be a 13-year-old kid again, and laugh like one, look up the following:

Borey

Lyndon: <https://s3.amazonaws.com/filmlinc/assets/uploads/comment/2013/Borey%20Lyndon%20-%2002%20stepson%20age.png>

Home A-Groan: <https://s3.amazonaws.com/filmlinc/assets/uploads/comment/2013/Home%20A-Groan%20-%2002%20Uncle%20Buck%20finale.png>

The

Ecchorcist: <https://s3.amazonaws.com/filmlinc/assets/uploads/comment/2013/The%20Ecchorcist%20-%2001%20director.png>

201 Minutes of Space

Idiocy: <https://s3.amazonaws.com/filmlinc/assets/uploads/comment/2013/201%20Minutes%20of%20a%20Space%20Idiocy%20-%2004%20final%20scene.png>

The closing “monolith” scene from *2001 A Space*

Odyssey: <https://s3.amazonaws.com/filmlinc/assets/uploads/comment/2013/201%20Minutes%20of%20a%20Space%20Idiocy%20-%2004%20final%20scene.png>

The Ecch

Files: https://www.bing.com/images/search?view=detailV2&id=5F5375C26F574C4808400A13D36360D552B847BB&thid=OIP.3JDWBbC26vrRhYUpfLx2aQHaE_&mediaurl=http%3A%2F%2Fcarl.draws.com%2Fcarls_animation_portfolio%2FMAD_MAGAZINE_files%2Ffiles_2.jpg&exph=400&expw=594&q=the+x-files+mad+magazine&selectedindex=0&qpv=the+x-files+mad+magazine&ajaxhist=0&vt=0&eim=0,1,2,6

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Space will only permit me to list, without URLs, other satires equally good, e.g., *The Black and Blue Hawks* (for *The Blackhawks* ... comic-book-hero pilots who flew F-104s, the shit-hot fighter jets of that day, destroying evil), *Plastic Sam* (like the “stretchy” member of the Fantastic Four), *Lord Jump* (for Lord Jim), *From Eternity Back to Here* (for *From Here to Eternity*), *Seven Itchy Years* (for *The Seven-Year Itch*), *Mutiny on the Bouncy* (for *Mutiny on the Bounty*), *Cheyenne Awful* (for *Cheyenne Autumn*), *Moroned* (for *Marooned*), ... *ad infinitum* ... *ad nauseum* ... *per omnia saecula saeculorum* ... *e pluribus unum* ... *non gustibus est disputandum* ... *illegitimi non carborundum* ... smoke ‘em if y’got ‘em ...

I agree with other commentators: *Mad* was overtaken and passed by a culture that is impossible to satirize because it has morphed into a satire of *itself*. How do you satirize a Vice President who will not be alone with any woman he is not married to, and who insists on calling his own wife “Mother”? How do you satirize a President who claims to be a “stable genius”, but who is neither – like Voltaire’s characterization of the Holy Roman Empire as “neither holy nor Roman nor an empire”? How do you satirize Sarah Palin’s interview where she claimed to be able to deal with Vladimir Putin because, on a clear day, she could see Russia from her front porch? How do you satirize a Republican candidate for the Senate whose antics with underage girls was allegedly motivated by a desire to preserve their “purity”?

Answer: You don’t.

Mad Magazine is lamentably gone because ***Mad Magazine* was too sane for the times.**

Chapter 8 – Of Magic, Miracles, and Faith

I like Pope Francis I. His openness to sexual-orientation minorities and his solicitude toward the poor are in marked contrast to the hard-line intransigence more characteristic of past Pontiffs. Church teachings about abortion, birth control – the “life” issues generally – and such matters as women’s ordination and same-sex marriage remain substantially unchanged. (I say “substantially” because, even on some of these issues, the Pope’s recent statements have been interestingly nuanced. God – so to speak – is in the details.) Bill Maher often says he strongly suspects that Pope Francis – “Pope Frank” as Maher sometimes calls him – is actually a closet atheist. (I think Maher is only half serious about such statements. But the operative word is “half”: I do think Maher is **half** serious.) The most recent papal statement to raise such a kerfuffle is his statement **denying** that “God [is] a magician, with a magic wand able to do everything”. To people – even devout, observant, faithful Christians – raised in a science-literate culture, this statement is about as under-whelming a sentiment as one could imagine. But for such people – scientifically literate, believing Christians, especially (though not exclusively) faithful Catholics – Pope Francis’ statement is, in the best sense, a bit of a booby trap, both epistemologically (what we can know in general) and theologically (what we can know about the Divine in particular).

Probably the most immediately obvious question the Pope’s statement begs is **What about miracles?** To take what is arguably the most obvious example, what about the doctrine of the Virgin Birth? For over two millennia, orthodox – lower case “o” – Christianity has taught that Jesus was conceived in the womb of Mary by the direct intervention of the Holy Spirit, and not, as with everyone else, through sexual intercourse. Parthenogenesis – conception without sex – is a trick that would make David Copperfield’s illusions look like my late Uncle Oscar’s amateur card tricks. Moreover, in the Christian understanding, parthenogenesis is **real**. It actually happened. It was not a stage illusion. Ditto Christ’s literal, physical, space-time historical Resurrection from the dead – which, St. Paul says, is make-or-break for the veracity of the Gospel message (I Corinthians 15:16-18):

For if the dead are not raised, then not even has Christ been raised. And if Christ has not been raised, your faith is futile; you are still in your sins. Then those also who have fallen asleep in Christ have perished ...

How does one argue that God is **not** a Magician – while at the same time believing and teaching that, through God’s intervention, life emerged, respectively, from both an unfertile Womb and from a three-days-occupied charnel house? In either case, that’s a helluva trick.

Well ... OK ... maybe it would be better to say that evolution, the Big Bang, etc., are not, strictly speaking, miracles, because, as my old Boeing-workstation log-on message used to say, “The Universe is just one of those things that happens from time to time”. That is, as stunning as they are, the Big Bang and evolution are nevertheless fully consonant with the laws of nature, whereas virgins having babies and a dead guy coming back to life and throwing a seafood buffet for his friends (John 21:12) are not. But wait a minute ... is the Big Bang really that different from the Virgin Birth? Doubtful. Far as we know, there are two possibilities. Either the Universe has always been here or it has not. If it has always been here – if our Universe partook of the old Fred Hoyle theory of continuous creation, or if it was the result of the

collision in higher-dimensional space of two or more 'branes ... i.e. Universe-as-'brane damage ... awright! ... **sorry** awready! ... *sheesh!* – then the Universe, or at least the multiverse that birthed it, is fully as eternal as God. That is, no more than God did the Universe have a Creator. Under either account, God is superfluous, a Whisker to be shaved away by Brother Ockham's sharp Razor. Or, if the Universe came about from some primordial Singularity, then the Universe arose *ex nihilo* ... literally and figuratively from nothing. And if we say God spoke the Universe into existence – **out of nothing** -- by Divine *fiat*, then God caused the Universe to come from nothing ... which – one more time – is a magic trick all the more impressive for being quite real and not an illusion. In that latter case, we are back to God-as-magician.

Similar remarks apply to evolution – although here there is a closer dependence on physical law, and therefore evolution is at least marginally more explicable, because, once the process gets going, there is a known set of physical laws to appeal to. There are some rules to the Game. So from that point on, it is a matter of cause and effect. One does not, as in the case of the Big Bang and ultimate origins, have to deal with all the quantum-level paradoxes of causality.

But the “magic quotient” is still pretty impressive, even so. How did life first arise, and, in any case, how did a mixture of chemicals, however complex, result, not only in life, but in intelligent life? Making the raw building blocks of life is a relatively simple matter of organic chemistry, as Prof. Harold C. Urey and his graduate student Stanley Miller demonstrated in their classic experiment: put some chemicals like the ones present on the ancient earth in a flask, run an electrical current through the mixture to simulate lightning, and ... **voila!** ... in a few days you will find an organic gunk coating the interior of the glass that contains, e.g., amino acids and other compounds vital to the building of proteins, DNA, etc. But it is safe to say that Homer, Mozart, and the Dalai Lama will not emerge from the flask, even so. Biology is one thing. Sentience is another. Getting from the former to the latter is a stunning bit of ... well ... *magic* – and what is even more impressive is that this magic is real: the rabbit was never really in the hat to begin with. What makes the “hyper-magic” trick known as evolution even more impressive is that evolution and speciation are like chess: *virtually impossible to play the same game twice*. I well remember how stunned I was when I read the late Stephen Jay Gould's book *Wonderful Life*, on the Burgess Shale fossil deposits in Canada, especially the part where Gould says that, if you started evolution over again from scratch, it is highly, highly, **highly** doubtful that the end-result would be anything recognizable as *homo sapiens sapiens*. Intelligent dinosaurs, maybe. No sentience, maybe. Even no life at all, maybe. But *homo sapiens sapiens*? Possible -- obviously! -- but highly improbable. As with a game of chess, *the outcome would be virtually impossible to duplicate*, even if you started out with the same set of rules and laws. This may not be magic in the strictest sense, but it will do quite nicely until the real thing comes along.

Finally, evolution and the Big Bang aside, there seems to be, on a lived, felt, and “existential,” level a kind of incorrigible human yearning for God to do magic, our from-the-eyebrows-up theological assent notwithstanding. I don't know, never having performed the experiment. But based on my experience in other contexts, I would be willing to wager an arbitrarily large amount of money – I'll even put my Starbucks Gold Card on the line – that, when the Pope celebrates Mass, there will be a part of the Liturgy where someone, usually a lector, reads the “Prayers of the Faithful” and asks the audience to respond with something like “Lord, hear

our prayer”. Among the prayers of the faithful – I’ve seen no exceptions in all the Masses I have attended – there will be requests for God to intervene to heal Mrs. McGillicuddy, who is hospitalized with varicose veins; to safeguard and restore to health Mr. O’Malley, who has heart problems; to prevail upon Palestinians and Israelis to live together in peace; etc., etc., etc. This sounds suspiciously like, their intellectual theologies notwithstanding, Christians are asking God to be a magician and to bring health out of sickness, peace out of belligerence, etc., etc. So the Pope’s professed aversion for viewing God as a Divine Magician seems to prevail only on a theoretical level. In actual nuts-and-bolts practice, religious folks want God to ... dammit all! ... “Do something, don’t just stand there!” – that is, for God to be what the old Schoolmen used to call an “efficient cause”. Maybe, if we take praying for “stuff” seriously, even an “instrumental cause”.

Of course, the usual response is to save God from being a Magician by arguing that, of course God does “do stuff,” but that God “does stuff” through human agency, i.e., that the true efficient and instrumental causes are human beings acting as God’s proxy. But in that case, Brother Ockham returns to the discussion, like Banquo haunting MacBeth’s feast. If curing Mrs. McGillicuddy’s varicose veins can be understood and explained only with reference to the skill of doctors and medical procedures rigorously followed, if, having taken those therapeutic factors into account, there is simply nothing else to explain or to understand, then can I not simply delete God and God’s intervention in my account of Mrs. M’s cure? In fact, and more generally, if feeding the hungry is something **humans** have to do, if healing the sick is something **humans** have to do, if comforting the bereaved is something **humans** have to do, if giving the thirsty a drink of water is something **humans** have to do, if reconciling warring parties is something **humans** have to do ... if living life on earth in community with others is something **humans** have to do ... then why pray at all? Meditation? Awareness? Mindfulness? Attaining *satori* / *kensho* / enlightenment? Yes. Sure. I practice, and can attest to the effectiveness of, *vipassana* meditation. Others practice similar disciplines, and can no doubt attest to their value. But in those cases, we are not asking anyone or any One ... to do any thing ... or any Thing ... least of all to be an efficient or instrumental cause for the achievement of some specific end-in-view.

I’m not down on Pope Francis. I’m really not. In fact, if you are religious, then I should think that his words on God as not a Magician would be welcome. One of the most surefire ways to steep the planet in misery has historically been to attempt to dragoon God into the attainment of some specific end which, however worthy it may be (and it often was not), makes God into an instrumental Cause. In fact, this is a pretty good hip-pocket definition of “superstition”. The trick is to follow this line of reasoning with enough integrity to accept **all** of its consequences, e.g., taking Mrs. McGillicuddy’s name off the prayer-request list.

Asking and expecting God to pull a rabbit out of the hat is just a “hare” too much. (No need to sharpen your pitchforks ... I was just leaving ...)

Chapter 9 – Media, McLuhan, and Memory

Does anyone besides me remember Marshall McLuhan?

Like a lot of other people, I was drawn to McLuhan and his writings, beginning as a college sophomore in the late 60s and continuing into graduate school in the early 70s. When I was an undergraduate, everyone and their dog was reading *Understanding Media*. So, at first just to follow campus fashion, I bought the paperback edition of the book and began reading. I was captivated from the first paragraph of the first page. In fact, one of my most vivid memories of that time is of being in my room in my parents' house and being totally engrossed in *Understanding Media* while a violent Kansas thunderstorm raged outside. I vaguely remember the air-raid sirens howling holy Hell, warning of an approaching tornado. But I did not come fully awake until my Dad, with a few choice Arkansas expletives invoking Divine assistance, interspersed with scatological references that turned my fundamentalist-Baptist mother's face white, literally grabbed me by my wrist, hauled me out of my chair, and crab-walked me to our basement. The tornado came close to us, but never hit us, and I eventually recovered from both the Kansas weather and my sophomoric (literally in my case) infatuation with McLuhan. Until recently.

These days, I have come to view McLuhan as a postmodernist prophet who, as St. Paul said of himself, was “born out of due season,” i.e., at least in McLuhan's case, ahead of his time. This is especially true when we consider McLuhan in the context of his distinction between “hot” and “cool” media – McLuhan's terms – as they are used in contemporary social media and in politics. Social media – Twitter, Facebook, etc. – are paradigmatic examples of McLuhan's concept of a cool medium for a couple of different reasons. First of all, social media are cool because they permit, *but never require*, active participation from subscribers. Once I define my list of Facebook friends, I need never touch my Facebook feed again: it is updated automatically. The other side of the coin, the side of the coin perhaps most relevant to politics, is that I have complete control over the people I invite into my Facebook-feed universe. In practice, this means that my Facebook universe only includes people who agree with me in all essential respects – and if anyone disagrees with me on a make or break issue, like the fitness of Donald Trump for the Presidency, I can “vote them off the Island” by unfriending them by editing my Facebook preferences. (Between the election and now, this actually happened about a dozen times: 6 in real life, and 6 on Facebook. I apparently had more incipient fascists in my circle of friends than I suspected!) In practice, this means that, over a modest span of time, my Facebook feed ends up being an echo chamber – my own left-wing-progressive (in my case) Fox-News-on-a-laptop. Secondly, precisely because social media are cool in McLuhan's terms, I am – another characteristic of cool media – spoon-fed content. Some Facebook posts are substantive discussions of politics – do Trump's ethical challenges and contempt for the law spell a looming constitutional crisis? – while others consist of high-def pictures of friends' lunches and the usual crop of great-danes-napping-with-kittens tableaux ... a *bricolage* of images juxtaposed by Facebook that I do not control.

And the “b-word” – *bricolage* – brings us to **politics**. And not *just* politics, either, but rather the entire world in postmodernist terms. What I see on my Facebook feed, what McLuhan (perhaps unwittingly, though I don't really think so) prophesied back in the early 70s, is the

world as seen through the fractured lenses of the postmodern sensibility: the World itself as the ultimate Cool Medium for a couple of reasons. First, etymologically, the word *bricolage* is derived from the Old French term for catapult, i.e., capturing the sense of an object made from disparate and unrelated pieces that are simply *catapulted or thrown together*; secondly, because the pieces pre-existed and did not have to be created, *bricolage* also connotes the idea of being spoon-fed the separate pieces which were already lying ready-to-hand and that one then more or less passively combines and lets fall together as they will with no or minimal intervention. Think of a painting by the late Jackson Pollock, who laid the canvas on the ground, and then dribbled paints of different colors from cans, perhaps with a flick of the brush at most, but who otherwise allowed the paint to flow and drip on the surface as it would. A late Jackson Pollock painting – he had been a painter for some time before developing the iconic technique usually associated with his name – may be thought of as *bricolage* with pigments. A late Jackson Pollock painting is actually a depiction of the world writ small. More particularly, it is the world of discourse / language writ small, and even more particularly, it is the world of politics writ small, perhaps even smaller.

As for the world of language and discourse ... that is far too large and complex a topic to tackle in a brief blog post, requiring probably at least one PhD, perhaps more than one, in a virtually opaque field like postmodernist interpretation theory. (This is what I studied at Oxford in 1988, and I survived only by virtue of many pub crawls and bibulous punt trips up and down the River Isis.) Suffice to say that a good example of this approach to language is the late Jean-Francois Lyotard's *The Post-Modern Condition*, which Lyotard wrote in support of the Canadian government's comprehensive appraisal of its education system. (I urgently recommend that, if you are new to this field, you start with something much more accessible, like Stanley Grenz's *A Primer on Postmodernism*. Respect your limits: Grenz's last name is the German word for "limit".) Lyotard, who is often credited with coining the word "postmodern" and "postmodernism," conceives of language and culture as an interlocking complex of discrete and very loosely related "language games" more or less along the lines conceived by Ludwig Wittgenstein during Wittgenstein's tenure at Oxford. (Wittgenstein did much of his writing literally in a foxhole in France while the chaos of the First World War raged around him.) Each discrete "language game" -- Wittgenstein's term, which Lyotard borrowed -- proceeds according to its own criteria and protocols -- including the language game known as science -- and also possesses its own conception of what constitutes truth.

Which finally brings us to politics: in particular, to politics as *bricolage*. The alt-right has mastered bricolage ... and Donald Trump himself is the grand master of *bricolage*. George F. Will and I do not agree on much, but we do agree wholeheartedly with Will's remarks in his 3 August 2016 column:

What Winston Churchill said about an adversary — “He spoke without a note, and almost without a point” — can be said of Donald Trump, but this might be unfair to him. His speeches are, of course, syntactical train wrecks, but there might be method to his madness. He rarely finishes a sentence (“Believe me!” does not count), but perhaps he is not the scatterbrain he has so successfully contrived to appear. Maybe he actually is a sly rascal, cunningly in pursuit of immunity through profusion.

He seems to understand that if you produce a steady stream of sufficiently stupefying statements, there will be no time to dwell on any one of them, and the net effect on the public

will be numbness and ennui. So, for example, while the nation has been considering his interesting decision to try to expand his appeal by attacking Gold Star parents, little attention has been paid to this: Vladimir Putin's occupation of Crimea has escaped Trump's notice.

Examine the public utterances of virtually anyone carrying Trump's ideological DNA -- Marine LePen, Geert Wilders, Nigel Farage, *et al.* -- and you, too, will conclude, as I think George Will is beginning to, that the European Enlightenment is basically over, in particular, its valorization of clarity, rationality, and cogency of discourse. Or at least, the West has paused for a (we may hope, historically brief) moment to catch its collective breath. For this runs deeper than mere rhetorical incompetence. It reflects a whole world view, a *Weltanschauung* at diametric variance with the Enlightenment ideal of coherency: **the World itself** is seen as **bricolage**, as comprising a cool medium that, for all our vaunted technological virtuosity, is essentially beyond our control. John Donne spoke more truly than he perhaps knew: "And new Philosophy calls all in doubt; / 'Tis all in pieces, all Coherence gone".

McLuhan would have understood.

Chapter 10 – Portrait of a Marriage

Every several years, perhaps every decade or so, a work of art captures my emotions and imagination, and sticks in my memory, even though it may be several years between viewings – assuming I ever see the original of the work at all. One such is Renoir's *Luncheon of the Boating Party*; another is Rembrandt's *Slaughtered Ox*; another, Picasso's *Guernica*; still another, Edouard Manet's *The Old Musician*. I have never seen the originals of the Rembrandt and the Picasso. I know them only from reproductions. But they haunt me. I recently discovered another such image while visiting the National Portrait Gallery in Washington, DC: Patricia Cronin's *Memorial to a Marriage* (hereafter *Memorial*).

Memorial is a bronze sculpture, cast from a marble original, depicting two women lovers, lying in bed wrapped in one another's arms in a gentle embrace. I am still processing the emotions evoked in me by seeing this powerful work a few weeks ago, but I think ... I *think* ... I am at the point where I can at least attempt a synopsis of the complex feelings.

The sculpture – I will concentrate on the bronze in the National Portrait Gallery – depicts the sculptor Patricia Cronin reclining on a bed with her lover – now wife – artist Deborah Kass. That phrase “lover – now wife” contains in suspension all the feelings seeing the work precipitated in me, and why I stood there in that gallery staring at it with such single-minded fixation.

The first is a feeling of profound peace. In fact, the phrase that came to mind as I stood in the gallery, near to tears, contemplating the work was that famous line from Dame Julian of Norwich's *Shewings of Divine Love*: “All shall be well, and all shall be well, and all manner of thing shall be most well.” Yet intertwined with this feeling of peace there was, paradoxically, a feeling of deep sadness and tragedy – and anger, even rage. Because Dame Julian's writings are embedded in a religious tradition – in this case, Catholic Christianity, but the following can be said of all forms of Christianity historically – that has for two millennia contorted itself ethically and theologically, and exerted its political and cultural influence, *precisely in order to make sure that, for gay and lesbian people, “all manner of thing shall [quite decidedly not] be most well,”* in fact, not well at all. That is why, on a deep, almost visceral, level, *Memorial* is can be viewed with profound ambiguity, why it is so susceptible to different, even opposite, interpretations.

What Cronin has achieved with *Memorial* is to subvert – while simultaneously reminding the viewer of – the long tradition of funerary art, especially funerary sculpture. Because of the semiotic kinship of *Memorial* with funerary sculpture, even as people who support marriage equality, LGBTQ rights, etc., celebrate the marriage of Deborah Kass and Patricia Cronin, we are reminded that, had the politics of LGBTQ rights played out differently, the same work that celebrates the mutual life and love of these two heroic women could easily have been the grave marker demarcating the Nation's *retreat* from full equality for people with minority sexual orientations.

Like all people of good will who take seriously the Constitution's and the 14th Amendment's guarantee of equal rights and equal protection of the law, I *want very much* to see *Memorial* as an unambiguous celebration of life for people like Patricia Cronin and Deborah Kass, because I have many friends, many of whom I consider family, who are gay and lesbian. But I am also realistic enough to know that vicissitudes of culture, politics – and religion, especially religion – could also end up rendering *Memorial* as a tombstone – like the tombstone marking Matthew Shepard's grave.

Hence the rage.

The gay playwright Jean Genet once said “A person’s position in bed is no one’s business but his own,” a principle that now, by the 21st century, should be self-evident. But this issue is still undecided, even in the wake of Supreme Court decisions like *Windsor* and *Obergefell*. Those crucial battles have been won, but the war is far from over at the Federal level. At the State level, so-called Religious Freedom Restoration Acts continue to proliferate about as virulently as the current measles epidemic, and, at least in more conservative / “red” States, people still get exercised about which bathroom trans students may use, even though no cases – **as in zero cases** – have ever been recorded of trans students assaulting their heterosexual classmates.

So just as the history of civil rights oscillates between hope and despair, in an analogous way, as I stared at *Memorial*, my interpretive / semiotic faculty oscillated between rage and joy, both reactions occupying the same affective space in my consciousness even as I looked at Cronin's work: rage at ongoing efforts to curtail full equality based on sexual orientation by State legislatures purporting to defend religious "freedom"; joy at the salient victories won by, e.g., the litigants in *Windsor* and *Obergefell*.

But I remind myself that such oscillation has always been the case when the Nation deals with the question of whether it has the moral courage to apply its own Constitution consistently to all oppressed and marginalized groups. During Reconstruction, the initial election of African-American candidates, most of whom were former slaves, to elective office oscillated with the subsequent corrupt Compromise of 1877 that made possible the withdrawal of Federal troops enforcing the Reconstruction Amendments, thereby making possible the rise of the Jim Crow South, and the rise of white-supremacist organizations like the Ku Klux Klan.

We may very well be experiencing a similar period of moral oscillation in dealing with the issue of LGBTQ rights, specifically marriage equality. Cronin's *Memorial to a Marriage* is located squarely on the fault line where the two political and moral tectonic plates collide: one plate advancing the restriction of LGBTQ equality; the other plate celebrating and promoting it. As I looked at Cronin's great work, I experienced in my imagination the cultural quakes induced by this opposition. I alternated between seeing *Memorial* as a monument to marriage equality and, a moment later, seeing it as a marker memorializing the death of same.

I am committed to seeing *Memorial* as celebratory. But, at the same time, I am realistic enough to know that celebration can turn to mourning if the national *Zeitgeist* once more favors the ostracism of sexual-orientation minorities.

That is why Cronin's work haunts me: it is not clear, at least to me, which part of that opposition will prevail. So perhaps the real value of *Memorial* is its function as a warning against complacency.

Chapter 11 – Poetry and the Limitations of Memor(y/ization)

Prof. Molly Worthen's recent reflection on the paucity of emphasis on memorizing poetry resonated with me very strongly, though for reasons she did not account for in her recent op-ed piece in the *New York Times*. Based on my own experience spanning an academic lifetime, I would suggest a different approach that could render memorizing poetry more relevant and even more pleasurable. My methodology is very simple and straightforward to describe and, perhaps for that reason, quite effective: instead of emphasizing rote memorization of poetry, **instill a love of the text itself**. Learn to love *Hamlet*, love it to the point that you read it over and over again during a lifetime, and memorizing the great soliloquy will most likely take care of itself. Above all, learn to reflect on your life experience within the enclosing context of literature. Herewith some personal examples, which include both poetry and prose.

The first time I can remember that a literary text revolutionized my life was when, in 8th-grade AP English in the early 60s, Mr. Gordon Morse, teaching English at Horace Man Intermediate School in Wichita, KS, where I grew up, one day handed out to his class mimeographed copies of Alfred, Lord Tennyson's great poem "Ulysses". I had always had, even at that callow age, a restlessness, an intellectual wanderlust. (I think that my one signal achievement in the American educational system, in fact, is that I managed to emerge from junior-high school with my capacity for gratuitous passionate curiosity intact. Many are not so fortunate.) Thanks to Tennyson's "Ulysses", I realized that I was not alone. *A poet writing in Victorian England was writing about me*. I remember cloistering myself in my bedroom that night and skipping dinner ... just to read that poem over and over again. (To this day, those few occasions when I smell mimeograph fluid always evoke memories of Tennyson's "Ulysses".) Now I can recite it by heart, not because I sat down and deliberately memorized it, but because awakened passion did what a brute determination to memorize could not.

In my twenties and into my early thirties, I was subject to periods of dangerously black clinical depression and abject panic attacks. That I am no longer thus tormented I credit to being married to a woman who is uniquely proficient at just putting up with me. But it was not always thus. During that grim time, I would turn ... yes ... to Hamlet's soliloquy and escape possible suicide by remembering Hamlet's haunting question about "what dreams may come, when we have shuffled off this mortal coil must give us pause". I continued living precisely because I was more disposed to "bear those ills [I] have than fly to others [I] know not of". I also read multiple dozens of times Albert Camus' *The Myth of Sisyphus* in my first undergraduate philosophy course at Wichita State University, and can still recite from memory the opening paragraph about suicide being the "only truly serious philosophical problem", and why ancillary questions are just "games". I do not know when I realized these texts were so intimate a part of me. As with "Ulysses," I just "woke up" one day and realized they were. Over time, in both cases and in both cases because those texts had become so "existentially" important to me, I had memorized the text without consciously realizing it or intending to.

The crisis was intensified, in fact, nearly rendered hopeless, when I discovered T. S. Eliot's **pre-1929** poetry, e.g., "Hollow Men" and, of course, *The Wasteland*. Both were, on vastly different scales –

“Hollow Men” on the level of individuals; *The Wasteland* on the level of the whole of western culture – autobiographical in the sense of being descriptions of my own self-perception during this period, i.e., when I was an undergraduate and early in my grad-student years. *We are the hollow men, / We are the stuffed men, / Leaning together, / Headpiece filled with straw. Alas! ... Thanks to The Wasteland*, I also understood intuitively and from the inside the vapidness of *Madame Sosostris, famous clairvoyante ... the wisest woman in Europe*, but behind whom stands only *A heap of broken images, where the sun beats, / And / the dead tree gives no shelter, the cricket no relief, / And the dry stone no sound of water.*

But fortunately for me, at some point in the process of dealing with my predisposition to depression and intermittent suicidal ideation, I discovered T. S. Eliot’s **post**-1929 poetry. (The “magic” year of 1929 turned out to be Eliot’s *annus mirabilis*: the year he converted to Christianity, joined the Anglican Church, and became a self-described “Anglo-Catholic” -- to the astonishment of good friends like Virginia Woolf.) I still saw myself in “Gerontion”: “An old man [though I was only in my thirties] in a dry month ... waiting for rain [whose] house was a decayed house”. “Gerontion” remains for me to this day one of the most starkly **terrifying** poems in the English language, much of the terror being traceable to Gerontion’s insipidity by virtue of his embodiment of the buried life Matthew Arnold had previously written about: *There rises an unspeakable desire / After the knowledge of our buried life, / A thirst to spend our fire and restless force / In tracking out our true, original course; / A longing to inquire / Into the mystery of this heart which beats / So wild, so deep in us, to know / Whence our lives come and where they go.* I could relate, and to this day can recite large passages of “Gerontion” from memory.

I say “fortunately for me”, because, along with “Gerontion,” I also discovered Eliot’s great cycle of **religious** poetry, *The Four Quartets*, which I am still, after forty-plus years, **very** much in the process of unpacking, and which I still consider to this day to be the greatest religious poetry ever written, worthy of favorable comparison to Dante’s *Divine Comedy*. (So compelling was this estimate that I even wrote an undergraduate thesis delineating the relationship between the two great works. Being a math, physics, and philosophy major, not an English major, at Wichita State at the time, I had to move heaven, earth, the Office of the Academic Dean, and the WSU English department to get permission, but it was worth the effort.) I do not have time to write, nor do you have time to read, the reasons why the discovery of the *Quartets* was the beginning of the decades-long process by which my life – I mean the following literally – was saved, and by which I was able to climb out of the black hole to which my childhood and adolescent experience with a dysfunctional family and an equally dysfunctional hyper-fundamentalist religious upbringing had previously consigned me.

So suffice to say that Eliot’s great accomplishment in the *Quartets* was to achieve a kind of *coincidentia oppositorum* of Comedy and Tragedy, depicting the dependence of each on the other, not only or even primarily at the level of the culture, but in the individual’s life – “the fire and the rose are one” (“Little Gidding”) -- a reconciliation rendered even more authentic by the fact that **Eliot had actually lived his poetry** in his own religious and spiritual struggles, and in his fraught relationship with his disturbed wife Vivienne Haigh-Wood, culminating in her commitment to a mental institution, in collaboration with Vivienne’s own brother. (To this day, I wonder if the lines Eliot wrote in “Little Gidding” refer obliquely to the pangs of conscience he suffered as a result of

this collaboration: ... *the shame of motives late revealed, the awareness / Of things ill done and done to others' harm / Which once you took for exercise of virtue.*) At the very least, the *Four Quartets* is a prominent exception to Eliot's later – and, I think, well justified -- contention that the greatest problem with religious poetry is that the poet usually writes more about **how she wishes she felt** than about **how she really feels**. Perhaps so. But the *Quartets* is a great exception. So I feel a great kinship with Eliot because, as he wrote in *Burnt Norton*, “[H]uman kind / cannot bear very much reality,” and in many related ways, Eliot and I both came very much to the edge of how much “reality” a human can “bear”.

All the above accounts for why, to this day, at least half the poetry I have “accidentally” memorized is drawn from the works of T. S. Eliot, from “Hollow Men” to “Preludes” (*the worlds revolve like ancient women gathering fuel in vacant lots*) to *The Wasteland* to “Gerontion” to *Four Quartets*. Despite being physically and chronologically separated, these works collectively constitute a kind of twentieth-century equivalent of *Pilgrim's Progress*. Different as are the poets, and prose authors, whose work I have “accidentally” memorized, they all share one common characteristic: beginning with Tennyson and “Ulysses,” they all, without exception, made explicit in words many thoughts, feelings, intuitions, insights, and just plain “hunches” that had been circulating in me for some time, and gave those thoughts, feelings, etc., an overt form. (That is true even of the French symbolists and the more recondite texts of Wallace Stevens: I don't “understand” them ... yet I **do**.) One concluding element of my “accidental” archive, this from *A Midsummer Night's Dream*: *The poet's eye, in a fine frenzy rolling, / Doth glance from heaven to earth, from earth to heaven; / And as imagination bodies forth / The forms of things unknown, the poet's pen / Turns them to shapes, and gives to airy nothing / A local habitation and a name.* Yes. Exactly.

During the junior-high year in AP English at Horace Mann I spent with Mr. Morse, he gave the class two poems to memorize, one for each semester: *The Wreck of the Hesperus* and *The Highwayman*. They were excellent poems, and, in a way, memorizing them and reciting them before the class, as we all were required to do at the end of each of the two semesters, was actually *fun*. But neither ignited, or was ignited by, a “fire in the belly,” like the foregoing examples. Neither “memorized themselves” as did, e.g., for me, “Ulysses” or the opening paragraph of *Little Gidding*. (Today, in fact, I remember *The Wreck of the Hesperus* primarily because of the hilarious and ribald Mad Magazine satire of the poem.) The common thread that unites the other poems is a love of the text itself, and the correlative love of the language – both of which were forged in the crucible of actual life-experience. I literally cannot imagine, nor do I particularly *want* to imagine, my life without, e.g., “Ulysses” and *The Idylls of the King* and Gerard Manley Hopkins’ “terrible sonnets” and Wallace Stevens’ “The Idea of Order at Key West” (and “The Snowman” and “The Emperor of Ice Cream” and “Sunday Morning” ... etc.) and A. R. Ammons’ “Easter Morning” and Eliot’s “Hollow Men” and *The Wasteland* and “Preludes” and *Four Quartets*. Prof. Worthen simultaneously **overestimates** and **underestimates** the importance of memorization: she **overestimates** it because she seems to confuse **knowing** a poem with **memorizing** it; and she **underestimates** it by seeing poetry as less than what it is, or at least as what it can eventually become: an actual load-bearing structure of one's identity and self-hood. A part of one's soul.

Chapter 12 – The Immanent Sacramental Theology of Shave Ice

You take your Sacraments wherever you can find them!

Or perhaps more appropriately for what follows, you take your *kensho* moments – your *bo-tree* experiences, your timeless instants of Damascene insight – wherever you can find them. My latest such was my discovery of shave ice as a kind of Sacrament or moment of enlightenment – the terminology is not important – on Diane’s and my recent visit to my in-law family in her hometown of Hilo on the Big Island of Hawaii. Once again, as with my experience at my father-in-law’s memorial service back in 2008, I was reminded that the moment is all. In fact, not only is the moment all, *the moment is all there is – **all there could be***. Not to be excessively prescriptive, but ... my intent in the following is to “pay it forward” by drawing on my experience to give you some friendly advice about how to discover the Universe in your own experience of shave ice, should you ever visit Hawaii.

But I’m getting ahead of myself. Not everyone knows of or has tasted shave ice. So some background first. I know about shave ice because I have been married for 32 years to a Japanese-American woman who was born and raised on the Big Island. (Though we met in Wichita, KS, where it is 1500 miles to the beach ... long story) Diane introduced me to shave ice, which I had never even *heard* of before, when I was in Honolulu for our wedding. I was instantly captivated. Love at first bite. Like virtually all experiences of the numinous, the experience of shave ice is the physically realized essence of utter simplicity: finely shaved – **not ground up or pulverized** – ice, molded into a sparkling pure-white sphere, placed in a cup or paper cone, and covered with a flavoring syrup of your choice. You eat it with a small wooden spoon. That’s it. That’s all. But from now on, the sacrament of shave ice really gets esoteric. So ...

o Piece of Advice #1: Pay close attention to the ice as it is being prepared

Actual, real, authentic, honest-t’Gawd shave ice worthy of the name, i.e., shave ice with the emphasis on “shave”, is made from a cylindrical block of plain water ice placed on a rapidly rotating plate and secured by a vise-like affair that screws down from the top. Then, as the ice rotates, it is literally *shaved* by a hand-held implement much like a big razor the size of a windshield ice scraper.

As the ice is being shaved, pay meditative attention to the ice as it is sheared away from the rotating round block. This ice-shaving process is sublime to observe, so sublime that the visual experience cannot really be captured in words. A really skilled shave-ice maker can wield the “razor” with such consummate skill that the ribbons of ice – seemingly only a couple of water molecules thin – curl away from the rotating round block and drift to the bottom of the ice-rotating apparatus with a kind of gossamer grace. There is something incorrigibly *mystical* about watching this. I repeat: the ice “membrane” does not *fall*; it *drifts*, so delicate that mere air resistance keeps it from falling. I have a wealth of pleasant memories of sitting with Diane in the dusty, old-fashioned general store of Honomu Town by Akaka Falls on the Big Island, the dust motes drifting in the brilliant sunlight streaming through the windows, watching intently as a master shave-ice maker peeled off elegant ribbons of ice with her razor. Now watch as the shave-ice maker scoops up the ice ribbons from the bottom of the apparatus

with something very like an ice-cream scoop and places the ice into a paper cone or cup, sculpting the mass of ice into a perfect, sparkling, white sphere as she does so. Next step is to watch as she pours the flavoring syrup – I say “syrup,” but it is not very thick, more like water – over the white ice sphere. There is some skill involved in this: pour too little, and there will be no taste; too much – remember, you’re in Hawaii, where it’s already hot -- and the ice will melt.

o Piece of Advice #2: Eating with intentionality

Take time to see and admire the appearance of the shave-ice sphere. This is easy to do if you ordered some flavor of bright color. For example, if you ordered strawberry, and if the shave-ice maker was quite skilled, your ice sphere will be nothing short of stunningly beautiful: imagine a perfectly cut, flawless ruby roughly the size of a regulation-size baseball, with thousands of facets, each brilliantly reflecting the sunlight. But for sheer subtlety of color, by my taste, vanilla is hard to beat. The ice will remain almost colorless ... at first glance. But glance again ... and glance again ... and glance again. Keep glancing. It takes time. But with a bit of practice, you will come to see in vanilla shave ice the coloration of a delicate, almost infinitely subtle pastel cream, so elusive that you see it best if you look at it out of the corner of your eye. There is nothing “plain” about “plain vanilla”.

Now, the next step is a multi-dimensional affair requiring serious discipline. You are ready to eat the shave ice. You were given – as all shave-ice customers are – a small wooden spoon and a tiny cocktail straw stuck into the shave-ice sphere. The purpose of the latter I describe below. For now, note only the following about the little wooden spoon:

2a: The little wooden shave-ice spoon, rather like the long staffs used in the Japanese martial art of *kendo*, is unassuming in its simplicity, but demanding in the discipline involved in its use. The paradox arises from the fact that using the spoon involves – obviously – skill in its *employment* while – much less obviously – great *restraint* in refraining from using it to control too much. As you have been visually admiring your virginally intact sphere of shave ice, coruscating in the Hawaii sun, the outermost layer of ice has been partially melting and trickling down the outer surface of the sphere ... and then, because it is still in contact with the ice underneath, *it has been re-freezing*. Chances are, this melting-and-refreezing process has been invisible to you. This means that, though you probably cannot see it, there is a more-or-less-rigid, couple-molecule-thick shell of water-flavor mixture now encasing the sphere. So actually taking a bite of your shave ice therefore means that you have to use the little wooden spoon to penetrate the shell of the shave ice. (The obvious Freudian overtones of this action I leave implicit.) Penetrating this shell is not a matter of sheer force, in fact, *least of all sheer force*. Instead, it is a matter of calm. Impatience will only result in too vigorous a thrust and the shattering of the ice shell – together with a potentially catastrophic collapse of part of the sphere. **Calmness of mind is all. Tranquility is all.**

2b: Even then, you cannot control everything. At some point, you will wield the little wooden spoon too vigorously or at an unfortunate angle ... or something ... and part of your ice-sphere will ignominiously collapse. You cannot control it. You cannot even control how or when it happens. And to even *attempt* to control it is to renounce control. “The wind blows where it will, and you cannot tell where it is coming from or where it is going.” So to eat shave ice is to practice both halves of a paradoxical discipline: (1) *exerting* control through calmness and a

respectful reluctance to intervene while (2) at the same time and with equal equanimity of mind, *renouncing* control and allowing the shave-ice sphere to behave as it will, not necessarily as you prefer. **Eating shave ice is a primal exercise in realizing that everything is not about you.** For ultimately and in a manner not easily expressible in words, (1) and (2) are synonymous. Heracleitus in the 6th century BCE unwittingly wrote the Prime Directive of all shave-ice aficionados: “The way up and the way down are one and the same”.

o Piece of Advice #3: Don't forget the straw

As you chip away, oh-so-delicately and with an oh-so-poignant sense of the tragedy of avoiding tragedy, at your shave ice, part of the ice-sphere will always be slowly melting and running down to the bottom of the cone or cup. Also, the melting will gradually transform the remaining shave ice in the container to a kind of semi-liquid / semi-solid slush. This is to be savored, held on the tongue in reverent and rapt contemplation, not unlike a devout Catholic savoring the consecrated Host. In a certain and very real sense, this slush, humble though it appears, is the sheer distilled essence of pure flavor, be that flavor strawberry or lilikoi or mango or vanilla. Again, this is an occasion for calm and equanimity, not haste. Furthermore, all shave-ice stands I am aware of offer a hybrid flavor called “rainbow” comprising an ice-sphere covered with multiple stripes of flavors. (This is me, but I personally am a shave-ice “purist,” preferring the gustatory integrity of a single flavor, but – again! – this is me.) I mention “rainbow” shave ice separately because, in the case of rainbow shave ice, when the various flavors / colors melt and blend into a common slush, the resulting liquid in the bottom of the container looks ... well ... “sludgy” and quite unappetizing. But in a manner that could perhaps only be appreciated by a confirmed Aristotelian or perhaps a medieval Scholastic sacramental theologian, the surface appearance – the Thomist *accidentia* – of the melted rainbow shave ice belies a true near-Divine splendor of flavors – the *essentia* lurking behind and beneath the humble and unappetizing appearance. Eating all shave ice – but most especially eating melted rainbow shave ice – is a pungent lesson in never judging by appearance.

To paraphrase J. B. S. Haldane's celebrated remark about the strangeness of the Universe “Shave ice is not only more splendid than we imagine, it is more splendid than we **can** imagine.”

Chapter 13 – The Imminent Immanence of the Zombie Apocalypse

I begin with a question: Izzit just me, or have *zombies* largely taken over popular movie and text culture in the United States? I do not think it is just me. Now, please understand at the outset: *I do not ask this question rancorously, or with the least pejorative intent.* Fact is, I like “zombie lit”! I am into the 13-volume-and-counting Kindle-book *Arisen* cycle of zombie lit, by Stephen Michael Fuchs and Glynn James, and D. J. Molles' *The Remaining* saga of I-don't-know-how-many volumes. Ditto Max Brooks' *World War Z*, both movie and book. I have seen, and loved, *Abraham Lincoln vs. the Zombies*. Ditto *Pride and Prejudice and Zombies*. I am an over-the-top fan of *Fear the Walking Dead*, *The Walking Dead*, and *Z-Nation*. When I take a sabbatical from reading about the history and interpretive methodologies of the US Constitution, I usually gravitate toward an imaginary world centered in the “Zulu Alpha” (ZA – “Zombie Apocalypse”, for the uninitiated -- though “ZA” has other technical, and less repeatable, meanings in American naval slang). Though altogether unintentionally, I even *walked* like a zombie – maybe a *Walking Dead* extra – back when my sciatica was much worse than now. So I have nothing to prove to anyone *vis a vis* “zombie-philic cred”: *I am down with zombies, yo?* Rather, I ask because zombies, the ZA, etc., have achieved such remarkable longevity as cultural memes. I am curious as to why. Disco did not last this long, nor did grunge. Nor did the Johnson campaign in '16. And let's pass mercifully over Trump's nano-second homoerotic-adjacent bromance with Scaramucci. *So anyway ... why zombies? And why now?*

If I can serious up for a minute -- dammit! that hurts! -- the following is my take on the answers.

I believe that zombies have begun to shamble about the cultural landscape because Western culture is preoccupied now with a kind of subliminal collective awareness that the European Enlightenment, which, ever since the middle 1600s, formed the moral, political, and intellectual compass for that culture, is at the very least endangered -- and may well be coming to an end. Increasingly, the dominant replacement paradigm is some form of postmodernist moral and epistemological nihilism. This *Zeitgeist* has, up until recent years, been articulated self-consciously and on a strictly theoretical level only in university departments of philosophy and linguistic studies. Postmodernist skepticism has been a subject of ongoing debate in, e.g., English departments, since sometime in the 1960s and Jacques Derrida's inaugural series of lectures on language and meaning at Johns Hopkins. But this was still on a strictly theoretical / academic level.

The critical difference is that now, in the late 20th and early 21st centuries, the ideology of postmodernism has escaped from the biosafety-level-4 containment of academic departments to infect practical politics, economics, and commerce. Over the last couple of years, I have written on this subject of postmodernist ideology escaping into the cultural ecosystem from its previously sequestered environment in university departments, partly as an attempt to provide a kind of “thanks-I-needed-that” slap in the face and partly also to strategize about ways to preserve the Enlightenment project through what may prove to be a coming cultural, political, and even scientific dark age.

So what does this have to do with the zombie meme?

I would argue ... *Everything*. Really persistent cultural memes often enact, or re-enact, on a smaller scale, what the culture perceives happening for real on a larger scale, and doing so through a rather elaborate retinue of semiotic conventions. Two examples:

o Think of the elaborate, overly refined, hyper-rococo style of dress, speech, and deportment, coupled with over-the-top *secularism* (not just *secularity*) and cynical skepticism about religion, that characterized Restoration England. England had been wracked by wave after sanguinary wave of religious war and political conflict that devastated the nation economically and militarily, followed by the protracted disaster of Cromwell and the rape of Ireland -- only to have the nation end up back where it started with Charles II's return in 1660. Hence the resurgent cynicism about religion, morals, and politics, manifesting itself in elaborate practices in dress and physical deportment. England *acted out* in popular culture the consequences of the Restoration .

o Or think of the analogously exhausted socio-political culture of Weimar Germany in the inter-war years that so haunts us in the bittersweet, merry nihilism of Liza Minelli singing "Cabaret". Everything had fallen apart socially, politically, militarily, and economically in 1919. Also diplomatically, in the wake of the Versailles humiliation. So in the cabaret culture, Germany acted out on the "micro" level the kind of "aw-t'hell-with-it-all" attitude that came to prevail in the culture on the "macro" level. "Life is a cabaret, old chum!"

So how is this analogous to the peculiar durability of the zombie cultural meme in the US of the second decade of the 21st century? There are several similarities that run in parallel with analogous aspects of both the English Restoration and Weimar Germany -- all replicated in miniature in zombie lit -- that are all connected by the common motif of postmodern nihilism.

o The zombie meme incorporates extreme skepticism about Reason

As everyone knows who has had even superficial contact with any zombie meme, from George Romero's classic *Night of the Living Dead* to *The Walking Dead*, the zombie brain consists of only the amygdala, which controls physiological urges and primitive instincts. *A zombie's amygdala controls only hunger*, in particular, hunger for the brains of the living. With zombies, the prefrontal cortex -- the locus of rationality, moral restraint, abstract thought, and aesthetic experience -- has shut down, having been completely annihilated by the zombie pathogen. Zombies are the ultimate, the *ne plus ultra* of climate-change deniers, young-earth-ers, etc., since being otherwise presupposes a capacity for the abstract thought requisite to science. At most, zombies can only deal with "alternative facts".

o Any piece of a zombie, however small, can go on living and hungering, provided only that the amygdala is intact.

A zombie's head, severed from the rest of the body but with the amygdala still intact, will go on living, and the mouth will go on biting. Most of the zombie is gone, but zombie behavior *persists*. This is vividly evocative of many of the columns Paul Krugman has written extending the zombie metaphor to conservative, specifically Trump-ian, economic theory. Trickle-down economics is zombie economics. Ditto the alleged lack of skills causing unemployment. Ditto, also, the idea that tax cuts for the elite result in job-creating economic growth. As Krugman argues, these assertions have all been exhaustively debunked, but they still shamle about the American landscape, zombie-like, attempting to bite the poor and the politically powerless.

o Even if the origin of the zombie virus is accounted for, that origin always redounds to the discredit of science and rationality

In *Night of the Living Dead* and *World War Z*, we are given only a very sketchy suggestion of an origin -- the zombie plague just ... *happens to happen*. Ditto *The Walking Dead*. In the *Arisen* novels, we do know that a renegade Soviet geneticist from one of the "-stans" of central Asia concocted a chimera pathogen from smallpox and some kind of myelin toxin that short-circuits nerve cells. Generally, in zombie lit, we are seldom given anything like a detailed, cause-effect account of the zombie virus's origin, and even when an origin is given, the zombie pathogen is *always the result of science*. So ... in the postmodern universe of *Zombieland*, there is ample reason to be skeptical about, even hostile toward, science and Reason.

In any case, and in parallel to similar memes in Restoration England and Weimar Germany, the real-world crisis of culture is replicated in miniature, this time in the form of a conflict between a shrinking minority of humans who continue to exemplify the rationality and intellectual / moral rigor of the European Enlightenment, on the one hand, and a burgeoning horde of newborn zombie converts to the unbridled appetites and feral ids of postmodern nihilism, on the other. The latter just mirrors the former. In fact, the phrase "unbridled appetites and feral ids" would be a pretty good hip-pocket characterization of the Trump Presidency. (As humor columnist Dave Barry would be the first to agree, "Unbridled Appetites and Feral Ids" would also be a great name for a heavy-metal rock band.) So ... bottom line: if you, like me, are a *Walking Dead* aficionado, we have to stop looking at *The Walking Dead* and *Fear the Walking Dead* as fiction. In reality, they are both *documentaries*.

Don't believe me? Think I am overstating the case? Turn on CNN or MSNBC -- or, hell ... Fox News -- anytime!

Chapter 14 – What is the Secret of Good Chinese Food? (No Fair Peking! ...)

I recently engaged in a Facebook discussion with a couple of Facebook friends regarding the kerfuffle about some disparaging comments the chef / gourmet-show host Andrew Zimmern made about Chinese food, and Asian food generally, in the US. Considering that the conversation about Zimmern's critique occurred among three Facebook friends, my remarks were uncharacteristically sharp. (One Facebook friend said "abrasive".) What aroused my ire was that the Zimmern critique provoked yet another round of bend-over-backward-til-your-vertebrae-crack political correctness that evidently holds that all works on the part of people of color, particularly people of color who are recent immigrants, should be immune from open and honest criticism and replaced by approbation on the part of the critic, particularly if said critic is a white Westerner. If such an attitude were confined only to discussions of matters culinary and gastronomic, it would be trivial. But that pattern of demanding absolute perfection, in this case, in the matter of culinary critiques, and seeing any deviation therefrom as at least a "micro-aggression", is part and parcel of the kind of attitude I have come to call "boutique progressivism" -- Bill Maher uses the term "liberal purist" -- and that was partially responsible for the rise of Donald Trump and Republicans to high office. Such progressives' standards were set so high that they approved of almost no one on the left, and the right rushed in to fill the electoral vacuum by default.

Be it noted up front that, in critiquing Asian cuisine in America, **Andrew Zimmern was critiquing the food, not the people**. Problem is, Zimmern's antagonists tend to equate the two: everything immigrant people of color do has to be viewed in terms of a rather conscious and intentional bias toward knee-jerk approval. Anything less is seen as "racism," at least implicitly. Zimmern described Asian food in America as "horseshit" -- his term, not mine -- and my discussion partners immediately jumped on this as *a personal attack on the chefs themselves, even though the accounts of Zimmern's critique (see 2 links above) contained not so much as a hint of personal animus*. One of my interlocutors argued that Zimmern should have moderated his critique, and the language he used to express it, because he was speaking to and of immigrants. (Speaking **to** immigrants, yes, but, as I said, not speaking **of** them.) Consequently, it was argued that he should have used more diplomatic language in his culinary critique. This advocacy of diplomacy contains more than a mere hint of what has often been called "the soft racism of low expectations", i.e., "Oh the poor dears from Vietnam or Cambodia or Thailand are far too fragile to handle honest language, and so might be frightened by excessive candor".

Indelicate honesty also recently got the astronaut Scott Kelly in trouble, because of Kelly's fulsome praise of Prime Minister Winston Churchill. (Scott Kelly is the brother of Mark Kelly, who is married to shooting victim Gabby Giffords.) This example of "boutique progressivism" is exceptionally egregious, because it was largely the steadfast leadership of Mr. Churchill that guided England through the darkest days of the Battle of Britain ... while the United States sat on the sidelines of the European theater, making money from President Roosevelt's program of Lend / Lease. PM Churchill's cardinal sin was that he had the bad luck to have been born into the British aristocracy of the late 19th century, in fact, born at Blenheim Palace, when Britannia ruled the waves, the sun never set on her Empire, and had imbibed the consequent sense of entitlement that went with both. Well ... *quelle domage*! I regard both as eminently forgivable -- in fact, to be expected -- but my siblings among "boutique progressives," who expect nothing less than perfection of their putative heroes, seem to expect such archetypal figures to be egalitarians born out of due season.

What particularly galls me, at least with respect to the Zimmern matter, is the knee-jerk, unreflecting, accusation hurled at Zimmern of “cultural appropriation.” Someone -- and I guess it has to be me -- needs to point out that, were it not for “cultural appropriation,” there would *be* no human culture. **Everything, every aspect of every culture, came from somewhere else**, some other culture, some other people. No exceptions. “Originality” is a non-existent abstraction, like the “frictionless surface” so familiar to undergraduate physics students.

But with regard to matters culinary, the people so quick to critique Zimmern for culturally appropriating Asian cuisine have evidently never heard the word “*peranakan*.” *Peranakan* cuisine, found almost exclusively in Singapore, resulted from the migration of Chinese food southward, through Thailand, and down the length of Malaysia – and finally to Singapore – absorbing and undergoing a myriad modifications and enhancements in the process. I have spent quite a lot of time in Singapore, and, thanks to a Boeing colleague who married a gracious Singaporean woman, I became well-acquainted with *peranakan* cuisine. It is spectacularly delicious, especially a divine creation called beef *rendang*. If this is “cultural appropriation,” then, frankly, all cultures should appropriate like hell, especially within their respective kitchens. (To be sure, I do reject cultural appropriation in matters pertaining to a people's deepest identity, which is why I oppose importing *seder* rites into Christian churches. Ditto *hanukkah*. *Seder* is, and ought to remain, Jewish, and *hanukkah* is most decidedly **not** the “Jewish Christmas”. But adapting, e.g., chicken *tikka masala* to Western tastes is not a matter of essential cultural identity.) I am amazed that people attacking Andrew Zimmern for his putative offense of “cultural appropriation” of Chinese food do not attack Singaporean – and Thai and Malaysian – chefs for the same crime. But I strongly suspect that there is a racial / ethnic element to all this: it seems to be quite permissible for Asian people of color to culturally appropriate from one another, but quite *im*permissible for a white Western dude like Andrew Zimmern to do the same thing.

As for Scott Kelly’s critique of PM Churchill ... boutique progressives should not throw stones as long as their own houses are made of glass. Either that, or they should take equal delight in critiquing their own heroes. I give you three examples: (1) Mahatma Gandhi, who said that instead of fighting to defend themselves, e.g., the Warsaw Uprising of 1944, the Jews of Europe should simply lie down, practice perfect pacifism, and allow the Nazi war machine to roll over them. Even as gentle a soul as Martin Buber was moved to express outrage at such a suggestion. (2) The latent racism of Jesus Christ vis a vis Canaanites. (3) The well documented evidence of Dr. Martin Luther King’s marital infidelities, so often recorded by Director J. Edgar Hoover’s surveillance. If boutique progressives, so anxious to valorize purity of mind and ideology, can forgive such acts and attitudes on the part of people like Gandhi, Jesus, and Dr. King, why are they so reluctant to forgive Andrew Zimmern’s honest critique of, e.g., General Tso’s chicken, American style? Since Gandhi, Jesus, and Dr. King were not white guys, perhaps I can be forgiven – though probably not – for at least entertaining the possibility of a latent ethnic element in this double standard.

Why is this important? Very simple ... the boutique progressive insistence on utter purity and perfection **makes it nearly impossible for boutique progressives to vote for political candidates who are simply good** – even for candidates who are simply “just good enough”. And when candidates fall short of that criterion, boutique progressives instantly light the torches, sharpen the pitchforks, and start looking for a short rope with a noose at the end and a tall tree to hang it from. The consequence is that, **by insisting on voting into office only angels, they end up being complicit in voting into office demons**. Demons like Donald Trump. (Yes, I insist that is the right word.) Remember the convulsions of apoplexy boutique progressives visited upon themselves about Hillary Clinton having

given a couple speeches to, e.g., Goldman-Sachs? So now, instead of Hillary giving speeches to Goldman-Sachs mandarins, we have Donald Trump giving speeches extolling the virtues of the Charleston neo-Nazis. Boutique progressives were aghast at the prospect of Hillary using military force to defend American interests – something Presidents all the way back to Washington have done. Instead, we have Trump creating a power vacuum in the Middle East by precipitously pulling American forces out of Syria, and perhaps out of Afghanistan, apparently at the behest of his fellow authoritarian, President Recep Tayyip Erdogan of Turkey. (Unfortunately, red lights did not flash, nor did alarm klaxons sound, when Vladimir Putin *praised* Trump for this withdrawal order.) At this point, I would gladly settle for a President who was indeed “just good enough” – though such a nondescript non-entity would no doubt be opposed by boutique progressives like Cornel West and Wes Howard-Brook, who would only vote for Jesus Christ ... oops! maybe not ... see previous paragraph.

This is my fear for the presidential election of 2020: that boutique progressives will once more demand absolute, utter, pristine, uncompromising, unadulterated perfection, the same way they demanded it of Andrew Zimmern, the same way they demanded it of Scott Kelly, and thereby, instead of settling for mere competence -- President Bush the Younger is looking pretty damn good right about now -- once more end up facilitating the re-election of Trump and thereby perhaps the final downfall of American constitutional government.

Like all forms of romanticism, boutique progressivism is, at its deepest root, and like all demands for perfection, in essence authoritarian.

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